all this and heaven too

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31031246.

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Not Rated

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by overnights

Summary

"I could probably triangulate an entry point," Entrapta says, "but whoever goes in there...well, it's the underworld. There's no way of knowing what's down there, and it's not a place for mortals. Anyone who makes that journey probably won't come back."

Catra's on her feet now, facing the room. Bow and Glimmer shoot her concerned looks; Catra ignores them. It's a shot in the dark, but Catra would take it blindfolded even in the light of day. She's crossed dimensions, defied boundaries, torn a hole in the fabric of reality. She's broken the world to destroy Adora; she can break it again to save her.

"Find the entrance," she says to Entrapta, her voice brittle but steady. "I'll go."

Notes

alternate title: Area Lesbian Watches The Love Of Her Life Die In Her Arms And Says *Watch Me Get Her Back (2021, colorized)*

happy catradora month everyone! this fic is the first chapter of my contribution to the 2021 catradora big bang. here's a playlist

See the end of the work for more notes

DESCEND

I want to meet you in every place I ever loved.
Listen to me. I am your echo. I would rather break the world than lose you.

- Amal El-Mohtar, from *This Is How You Lose The Time War*

(THE RIVER)

Catra has never known a life without Adora.

They've always been together, in one way or another. In childhood, they were inseparable; they braved everything together, the Fright Zone and the Horde and the Weeping Woods one day before a skiff and a sword split them apart. In war, they were inseparable in a different way; although they weren't together physically, they circled each other like planets in orbit, their lives overlapping like eclipses. They'd been two halves of a war, two sides of a coin. Still inextricably intertwined, after everything.

Adora has always been Catra's constant: her horizon, her north star, the point around which her world rotates. Sometimes - in the heat of battle, in the dead of night - Catra thinks that Adora has been the truest part of her. She can't imagine a world without Adora, can't imagine a life that isn't built in her shape. To Catra, there is no possible reality where Adora is anything other than alive.

But now, sitting in the Heart of Etheria with green light spreading across the ceiling and the walls crumbling around them, Catra

presses her head to Adora's chest and hears only silence.

--

"No," someone says. They say it again and again, until the words trip over themselves, run into an unintelligible mess: no, no, no, *nononononono.* It takes Catra a long time to realize that she's the one saying it, and longer still to stop.

The walls are no longer crumbling; the green streaks of Prime's virus are now slowly receding. Catra barely notices any of that. All she can see is Adora, lying stiller than Catra has ever seen her, unblinking, unbreathing. She could almost be sleeping, except Catra knows better than anyone that Adora has never slept so calmly in her life.

Catra shakes Adora's shoulder, gently at first, then harder. Adora doesn't react.

"Adora," Catra says softly. "Adora, wake up. You have to wake up." Then, desperately: "Please. *Please*."

Catra forgets where she is, how she got there. She forgets everything but Adora. She gets down on her knees and pleads like she never has before in her life, unbending her pride and throwing it to the winds, begging Adora for something, anything: a word, a whisper, a sign of life. Catra would give the rest of her breaths for Adora to take one more.

Adora doesn't respond. Adora doesn't breathe. She lays where she is, a perfect stone carving of a person, and for the first time, Catra notices something: Adora is glowing softly, limned in golden light that shines outwards from her body. It's as if she's frozen in time and space, preserved in gold like flies trapped in amber. There's something eerie and otherworldly about it; the light feels like something distant and alien, telling of a place where Catra cannot reach. When she touches Adora's hand, it feels like touching anyone, and that's how Catra knows.

Adora is dead.

Catra throws her head back and screams in agony. She's been suffocated by shadows and broken every bone in her body and fallen through a hole in the fabric of reality, but nothing has ever hurt like this: it's a wild, sharp-edged, gaping ache that seems to tear her chest apart, her heart an open wound, her ribs a cage of shattered sorrows.

She screams louder than she did on Prime's ship, louder than she ever has, but Adora does not wake, and this, more than anything, is proof that she's truly gone.

If she could hear me, Catra thinks dully, throat aching, quiet falling around her in the ringing echoes of her screams, *she would come back. She wouldn't leave me here to suffer alone.*

Catra leans her head against Adora's chest once more. Hot tears spring to her eyes, but she blinks them back. She reaches out, touches all the parts of Adora that she'd been afraid to before; she traces her fingers across Adora's collarbones, her cheeks, the sharp line of her jaw. She can feel words piling up in her throat, confessions that were ready to be spoken but now might never see the light of day; she'd finally been ready to tell Adora, ready to say what she'd been holding back for fifteen years of her life -

"Adora," Catra whispers once more, and it's like speaking to the stars. There's a cold and impossible distance between them, an unnavigable ocean that splits them apart like the continents.

Adora is gone. She's truly gone.

Catra buries her face in Adora's hair and lets herself cry.

--

Catra doesn't know how long she stays there. It could be days, hours, minutes. Finally she hears the sound of footsteps in the corridor, and with an effort that feels Herculean, she lifts her head to see Bow and Glimmer standing there.

“Catra,” Bow says, and then his gaze slides beyond her, lands on Adora’s unmoving body. Catra watches his face fall, a slow and agonizing descent from confusion to realization to anguish, and it feels like a knife to the chest.

“Adora,” Glimmer says, her voice cracking. She rushes to Adora’s side, kneels down beside her. “Adora, get up. Adora, listen to me.”

“She can’t hear you,” Catra says, her voice flat and remote. It feels like she’s speaking from the bottom of the ocean. “She - she’s gone, Glimmer.”

Glimmer whirls to face her, tears cutting trails down her face. “What do you mean, she’s gone? What the fuck happened here? How can she be gone?” Her expression is a mask of rage, and for a brief moment, Catra feels like she’s looking in a mirror.

“The virus,” Catra mutters. “The failsafe...she couldn’t transform properly. I don’t know. And now she’s - ” The word *dead* falls to pieces in her mouth. “What happened out there?”

“All the chipped people are saved,” Bow says quietly. “Prime’s ship disappeared - it turned into a tree in the upper atmosphere. All of Etheria was saved, but - ”

But it cost Adora her life, Catra thinks, and she wants to think that the sacrifice was worth it; she knows that it’s what Adora would want, but she can’t agree. She can’t think of a single thing in the world that would be worth Adora’s death, and she can’t think of anything she wouldn’t sacrifice to get her back.

Bow is crying. Glimmer is staring blankly at Adora’s body, one hand resting listlessly against her arm. The Heart is silent, the air hazy and thick and heavy with grief. There’s nothing left to do but mourn.

“We should move her,” Glimmer says at last, her voice subdued. “We can’t leave her here.”

Catra feels a sudden resistance rising in her, a reluctance to move; she doesn't want to walk away from the last place that Adora was alive. But Glimmer is right - they can't leave Adora here. Catra can't leave her at all.

Catra gently picks Adora up, carrying her body the way that Adora once carried her off a spaceship - days ago, centuries ago. Adora is heavy, but Catra bears her weight without a second thought. Each step feels like penance, atonement for allowing Adora to die.

If one of us had to die, Catra thinks, head bent low, Adora cradled to her chest, *it should have been me.*

Another tear falls from her face and drops onto Adora's, sliding slowly down her cheek. Through the blur of salt that clouds Catra's vision, it almost looks like Adora is the one crying.

--

Outside, Etheria is a riot of life, awash with color. New trees spring half-formed from the ground, green grass rising taller than Catra's ever seen it before. The world seems frozen between winter and spring, halfway to rebirth. High above them, a tree hovers above the earth: Prime's ship, transformed.

None of it holds any significance for Catra. The only magic in Etheria that's ever mattered to her is lying dead in her arms.

When they return to Bright Moon, Glimmer calls the rest of the princesses into the war room. They gather around the table, weary and grief-stricken, glancing at Adora's body with disbelieving eyes. Perfuma starts crying quietly; Scorpia cries too, much more loudly. Mermista gazes blankly into the distance, looking shell-shocked. Entrapta stares at Adora with unfocused eyes, as if confronting an equation that doesn't compute.

Catra doesn't sit at the table. She remains on the floor, arms wrapped around Adora. She's starting to lose feeling in her hands, but she doesn't care. She won't let go of Adora, not yet.

The second she lets go, it becomes real.

“So Prime is gone,” Frosta says finally, “but so is She-Ra.”

“You mean *Adora,”* Catra snaps, rage simmering beneath her skin. “Stop talking about She-Ra. She isn’t the most important part of Adora. She never was.”

Frosta shrinks back, and Catra feels a stab of regret. Frosta’s just a kid, she reminds herself. She’s too young to see this, to deal with this. She’s too young for this war, just like they were.

“Sorry,” Frosta says frantically, tearfully.“It wasn’t - I didn’t mean that. I just meant - ”

“It’s okay,” Catra mumbles. “Whatever.”

“Are we having a funeral?” Scorpia asks. She’s practically drowning in sobs, claws pressed against her face as if to stem the flood. It’s a losing battle. “I know that everyone in Etheria would - would want to come and honor her. Adora saved us all. She’s a hero.”

Catra chokes at the thought, panic flooding her chest at the thought of burying Adora. She can’t handle the thought of leaving her to rot beneath the earth, can’t fathom the idea of never seeing her face again. Adora is so warm and bright, full of light and life; being entombed in the suffocating darkness of the ground would be the worst possible end for her.

“No,” Glimmer says quickly, and Catra knows that she’s thinking the same thing. “Not a burial, anyway. Not - not yet.” She clears her throat, blinking rapidly. Bow, standing next to her, wraps an arm around her waist, and the gesture makes Catra’s heart ache.

Micah speaks up from the head of the table. “We can lay her to rest in the throne room,” he suggests. “I’ll bring a table in, and blankets. She can stay there for however long.” He looks at Catra with an unbearable pity in his eyes. “She’ll be well taken care of, I promise.”

Catra nods to him, a sick kind of gratitude welling up in her. She thinks: *I killed your wife.* She thinks: *you shouldn't be showing me this kindness.*

"Uh," Mermista ventures, "does anyone know why she's glowing?"

"She did that once before," Glimmer murmurs. "On the ship, when she healed Catra."

Catra winces at the memory. She didn't see any of it, but she remembers feeling it: a warm glow that spread through her chest, spreading summertime along her bones, bringing her back to life. She'd opened her eyes and seen Adora smiling at her in relief, so tired but so beautiful -

"It went away once she was done healing," Bow recalls. "But now it's not going anywhere. It's like it's permanent."

"I would theorize," Entrapta says, her voice stripped of its usual enthusiastic lilt, "that it's because she's stuck in mid-transformation. She couldn't become She-Ra, not fully, but she was on the way before the failsafe took effect. This golden light she's emitting is proof of that, and it will most likely preserve her body as it is right now."

Catra lets out a tiny breath, a faint lessening of the panic trapped in her throat. At least she won't have to watch Adora slowly decay.

"I think that now she's trapped in a sort of stasis period," Entrapta continues. "Like being stuck between dimensions. She's hovering somewhere between life and death; her body remains, but her soul does not. She's no longer in this world, but she has not yet fully passed to the next."

A wild hope sparks in Catra, clinging desperately to the ends of Entrapta's words. If she's saying what Catra thinks she's saying…

"Wait," Mermista says slowly, carefully. "Are you saying that - "

“Yes,” Entrapta answers. “She’s not quite dead, or even if she is, there may be a way to get her back.”

Mermista narrows her eyes. “What’s the catch?”

Entrapta’s eyes are downcast. “Someone would have to descend into the underworld to find her soul.”

Micah shakes his head. “That would be a suicide mission.”

“I could probably triangulate an entrance point,” Entrapta says, “but whoever goes in there...well, it’s the underworld. There’s no way of knowing what’s down there, and it’s not a place for mortals. Anyone who makes that journey probably won’t come back.”

Catra’s on her feet now, facing the room. Bow and Glimmer shoot her concerned looks; Catra ignores them. It’s a shot in the dark, but Catra would take it blindfolded even in the light of day. She’s crossed dimensions, defied boundaries, torn a hole in the fabric of reality. She’s broken the world to destroy Adora; she can break it again to save her.

“Find the entrance,” she says to Entrapta, her voice brittle but steady. “I’ll go.”

--

They lay Adora in the throne room, atop a large bench covered in gold and white blankets. Catra sleeps on the floor beside her, unwilling to leave her side for even a minute. They’ve been apart too long; she can’t bear to waste any more time.

Entrapta works in the corner of the room, mumbling to herself, scrawling complex calculations on a large white board. Catra doesn’t bother her, even when impatience scratches at the back of her skull - she knows that Entrapta is working as fast as she can.

Bow and Glimmer join them, sitting side by side with Catra and searching futilely for something to say. Glimmer is called away

sometimes to take care of queen duties, but she always returns to them at night. The three of them sit together and watch over Adora, occasionally talking, but mostly remaining quiet, each trapped in their own grief.

"What was she like?" Catra asks on the third night, breaking the silence that's settled over them like a funeral shroud. "When she first joined the Rebellion, I mean. After - " *After she left me.*

Glimmer snorts. "Oh, she was a disaster. But in the best way possible. She killed her featherbed the first night she was here because it was too soft."

"She tried to trick the palace guards into thinking she was one of them," Bow adds, a smile creasing the corner of his mouth. "All she had was a helmet and a blanket."

"She made a list of notes as long as the carpet when she was preparing for Princess Prom," Glimmer says. "She overthought it, like, *so* hard."

Catra had expected that hearing Bow and Glimmer talk about Adora would sting, but it doesn't hurt as much as she'd thought. Instead, it brings a small flame of warmth to her chest. Adora may be gone, but the memories of her live on.

"Yeah," she says wistfully. "Sounds like Adora."

"And," Bow says, glancing at her, "she never let go of you."

Catra stares at him, her heart aching desperately, reaching for belief. "Really?"

"Really," Glimmer confirms. "She was always thinking about you. *Always.* It was really annoying at first." She sighs, her eyes softening; she rests a hand carefully on top of Catra's, a gentle touch that leaves space for Catra to pull away easily. Catra doesn't.

“She never gave you up,” Glimmer says softly. “You know that, don’t you?”

Catra thinks of Adora in the Fright Zone, on Prime’s ship, on Darla. She thinks of Adora holding out her hand: a peace offering, a turning point. She thinks of what Adora said to her: *I never wanted to leave you. I’m going to take you home, I promise. I never hated you.*

Adora may have left her, but that wasn’t the same as letting go. Their lives have always been too closely woven to ever truly unravel.

“Yeah,” Catra says quietly, and for the first time in her life, she believes it. “I do.”

Bow leans into her, and Glimmer wraps an arm around her shoulders. Catra lets herself sink into the temporary comfort, and tries not to think about how the embrace is missing a fourth person.

“I’ve got it,” Entrapta calls from across the room. She looks exhausted; her eyes are dark with fatigue, and her hair is falling limp around her shoulders in a way that Catra’s never seen before her. “I found the entrance.”

Catra feels dread coiling in her stomach, working its way upwards into her chest. Entrapta looks shadowed, haunted by her own discovery.

“Where is it?” Catra asks hesitantly. Beside her, Bow and Glimmer hold their breaths.

Entrapta sighs heavily. “It’s on Beast Island.”

Bow and Glimmer gasp, but Catra feels an odd sense of calm descend on her. Beast Island was once a place of nightmares, but now the prospect of facing it barely registers as a threat. Adora’s death is a nightmare without parallel; anything else pales in comparison, vanishing into the background of childhood legend

alongside grimdark horrors and monsters under beds and every other thing that Catra used to fear.

“Okay,” she says, and her voice is unwavering. “Can we take Darla there?”

“You can’t,” Glimmer says, horrified. “You can’t go to Beast Island.” There’s a note of fear in her voice; belatedly, Catra remembers that Micah spent half his life on that island, plagued by demons that he still won’t speak about.

“It would be really dangerous,” Bow says, frowning. “Beast Island is bad enough, but the Underworld...”

Catra stares at them defiantly. “Are you telling me you wouldn’t take this chance to save Adora?”

Bow lowers his head; Glimmer looks away. Neither of them answer, and that’s how Catra knows she’s won.

“At least let us come with you,” Glimmer says finally. “We would. You know we would.”

“No,” Catra answers. “You’re the queen of Bright Moon, Glimmer. They - we can’t risk losing you. And Bow...well, you’re going to be king someday, if you two ever suck it up and tell each other how you really feel.” Glimmer and Bow turn red, pointedly looking away from each other in embarrassment, and Catra smirks slightly.

“Besides,” she says, her amusement fading now. “This is something I have to do alone.” She thinks of a dusty storeroom, an enemy spaceship, a promise made again and again. “Adora promised to take me home once, and she made good on it.” She looks over at Adora now, motionless on the bench, and feels a fresh shred of pain curl around her heart. “It’s time for me to return the favor.”

--

The trip to Beast Island is silent. Entrapta hovers over the control panel; Bow and Glimmer sit with their backs against the wall. They place Adora in the captain's chair, and Catra rests on the chair's arm next to her. It's so similar to the journey back from Prime's ship that for a moment, Catra almost forgets that they're not safely on the way home together.

"We're here," Entrapta announces. Catra looks up through the windshield to see the dreaded shape of Beast Island looming ahead, razor sharp points of purple stone sticking upwards into the sky as if to pierce the moon. Her stomach drops.

Entrapta fiddles with the controls, and Darla begins a slow descent, touching down lightly. Darla's door opens, and Catra turns to Bow and Glimmer.

"You can't come any further with me," she says.

Bow nods. Glimmer glares at her, but then her expression shifts to concern, and Catra knows that she's worried beyond words.

"You better come back," Glimmer says, pulling her into a bone-crushing hug. "We can't lose both of you."

"Make sure you come home," Bow says, wrapping his arms around both of them. "And bring Adora with you."

Catra hugs them tightly, wondering if she'll ever see them again; then she pulls away and looks to Entrapta.

"Thank you for getting me here," she says, and Entrapta nods.

Micah steps forward, out of the shadow of the airlock door, and Catra looks to him, gratitude and guilt wrestling in her chest; she knows what it costs him to return to this island, even if he's not setting foot outside the ship.

"There is a path in the center of the island, leading down into the ground," he says. "I never had the courage to explore it, but now I know that it's the right way for you. Take that, and you'll find the

river.” He reaches for Catra’s hand, presses something small and round into it. “This is the toll, for the ferryman. And Catra - don’t eat or drink anything while you’re down there.”

“I won’t,” Catra says. She closes her hand around the toll, shoves it deep into her pocket.

“When you exit, you could come out anywhere in Etheria,” Entrapta says. “I’m programming Darla to cruise around between the kingdoms while we wait. If - when you get Adora back, Darla will lock onto her signature and we’ll be able to find you two.”

“Okay,” Catra says. She takes one last look at Adora’s body, still radiant with light as she rests in the captain’s chair, and says a silent goodbye. “I’m ready.”

“Good luck,” Entrapta says. She opens Darla’s door, and Catra steps out onto the shore. The door closes and Darla lifts off again, and Catra is alone on Beast Island.

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The air is eerily quiet as Catra walks to the center of the island. There’s none of the haunting shrieks or ghostly echoes that she would have expected. In a way, the silence is almost worse; it hints at a lingering violence that transcends sound. She wonders, briefly, whether there’s some unheard predator lurking in the shadows behind her, one of the monsters of Beast Island that the older cadets used to tell tales about in the darkened bunk room, but then brushes it off. Worry is a luxury that she can’t afford right now.

She crosses through ruins wrapped in black and purple vines, the splintered walls shifting in the mist like a living bruise. The walk to the center of the island seems to take no time at all; within minutes, she’s standing in a clearing ringed with tall black stones. A path leads downwards to a gaping hole between two slanted rocks - the path that Micah had told her about.

Catra takes a deep breath, then another. She thinks of Adora as she was before: Adora on the rooftop of the Fright Zone, smiling crookedly at her; Adora in a red dress, framed by the soft pink glow of the ballroom lights; Adora raising her sword, eyes gleaming bright with determination. She thinks of everything she's lost, and everything she'd do to get it back.

Without a backwards look, she walks down into the depths of the earth.

It's pitch black, the darkness pressing around her like nighttime has swallowed her whole. Catra moves slowly forwards, her eyes straining to discern any hint of light, but there's none. The air is cold and damp, and the tunnel feels suffocatingly small. Catra grits her teeth and continues on, forcing through the panic that's curling in her chest.

Just when she feels like she's about to scream if she spends one more minute crushed here between the earth and the dark, the tunnel twists and widens. Catra finds herself on a wide path illuminated by rushlights flickering along the walls, shedding a sickly orange light down upon her. The air is different now, becoming drier and hotter, and the ground feels softer under her feet. Up ahead, there's the sound of rushing water.

One more twist in the tunnel, and it ends, giving way to a sandy bank. Catra finds herself standing in a desert beneath a pale pink sky, stretching out towards an indistinct horizon. In front of her lies a wide river, spilling across the land in a trail of blood-red water. Catra stares in disbelief - the river is made of *fire* . Flames dance against the banks like waves, brushing the air with currents of heat.

On the shore closest to her, a long boat is tied up to a dock. There's a figure standing at the helm, their face hidden by a dark cloth. The ferryman.

Catra walks slowly towards him, tensed in preparation for a fight. Her hands curl into fists automatically, her body twisting into a

weapon; it's a reflex, a remnant from the war that's still not over.

The ferryman turns to her, his face still obscured by shadow. "A traveler," he says, his voice deep and rich, the tone ringing with otherworldly notes. "You wish to cross."

"Yes," Catra says curtly.

The ferryman holds out a hand in a silent demand. Catra reaches into her pocket, takes out the token that Micah gave her; she places it on the ferryman's palm, watching as his fingers curl around it. He nods slowly. "Come aboard, then."

Catra steps onto the boat. The ferryman pushes off from the bank with a long punting pole, moving them across the river. Flames rise around the boat, licking at the sides, but the polished wooden planks don't burn.

It's a slow crossing. Catra's eyes water from the heat, her lungs burning from the acrid smoke rising from the waves. She watches the ferryman out of the corner of her eye, not willing to turn her back on him.

After what feels like an hour, the boat's prow touches the far shore, and the ferryman gestures towards the bank. "Go on, traveler," he says. "Continue with your hopeless mission." His eyes are still shadowed, but his teeth flash white in a grin, sharpened to cruel points. Catra thinks of the peaks of Beast Island.

"The land of the dead," the helmsman continues. "How long do you think it will be until you join them?" He leers at her: a predator searching for prey, a blade searching for entry.

Catra wants to spring at him. She wants to take back her payment, to push him overboard, to tear him apart.

"Go fuck yourself," she says, and steps onto the shore.

:::

(THE FIRST GATE)

The desert rises to meet her.

Rolling hills of sand sprawl out before her, dunes pushing against the skyline, all of it colored the rich, rusty crimson of fresh blood. It's soft and yielding underfoot, pulling at Catra with every step. It reminds her of the Crimson Waste, but worse; at least the Waste was on familiar ground. This place is different, alien. There's a sense of unearthly gravity to it, an oppressive force that wraps around Catra's shoulders like a mantle. It's as if the entire desert is trying to drag her beneath the surface of the sand.

Catra's mouth is already dry, her head aching from the heat. There are no streams in sight, and even if she found one, she couldn't drink from it; Micah's warning rings loudly in her ears. She sighs and pushes onwards.

She crosses dune after dune, sinking deeper with every step. The dryness of the air pulls at her lungs, ripping breaths from her in measured gasps. She can't help but think of the Waste - and then she can't help but think of Adora.

The Crimson Waste had been hot and dry and harsh, but it had also been a haven, a refuge from the endless fear and obedience of the Horde. She'd been beyond Hordak's reach, beyond Shadow Weaver's grasp. She'd had the freedom she'd been dreaming of from years.

Scorpia's voice echoes in her mind, the sound distorted: *You seem happy here. Why not stay?*

Adora, Catra had thought. She'd almost said it aloud. The answer had been Adora. The answer had always been Adora.

Catra shakes away the memory and trudges on.

She walks for what feels like miles, hours. Distance, space, time; all of it blends into a meaningless blur, shimmering on the horizon: an illusion, a mirage. She's learning that the underworld is a liminal space, a line half drawn between river and sky - nothing here matters, at least not that she can see.

As she walks, she passes fragments of civilization, falling and breaking against themselves. Villages sit abandoned, their clay houses gutted and ghostly; collapsing pyramids crumble towards the sky, stray stones scattered around their bases. There isn't a single sign of life among them, and Catra doesn't go near them; they're nothing but rot and ruin, whispering the echoes of a thousand lives lived before.

The land of the dead, the ferryman had called it. Even without corpses and cadavers, even without spirits or shadows, Catra thinks that the title is fitting. There's an unmistakable emptiness to the desert, a void where life should be. Catra's heart beats out a steady rhythm as she walks, and it feels too loud in her ears. She's the only living thing around.

She wonders about the villages, the pyramids. She wonders if they ever had real inhabitants. Somehow, she doesn't think they did. This land is too barren to have ever known the touch of the living.

Except me, she thinks.

More sand. More dunes. Catra feels heavy, heavier than she ever has before, like she's carrying the burdens of the dead as payment for passing through their land. It's the weight of the ocean, the world, the entire sorry sky. Her mood falls as she walks, bleeding slowly from determination to despair. As if in reflection of this, up ahead of her, a heavy mist starts to rise across the ground.

Catra halts, but the mist doesn't stop; it rolls onward, wrapping her within a cloud of silver haze until she can barely see the way in front of her. She presses forward anyway, her senses deadened by the fog, and that's when she hears it.

Somewhere in the distance, a dog starts barking. It's only one bark at first, but then it becomes more: a repeated cry, a call waiting for a response. Another bark joins the chorus, and then another, and the sound fills Catra with a visceral, inexplicable fear that sends a paralyzing chill crawling down her spine. She stops dead in her tracks, staring into the mist in search of the source.

She doesn't have to wait long.

A jet black jackal streaks out of the mist, fur bristling, teeth bared. Yellow foam spreads over its lips as it snarls at her. More jackals follow, spreading around in a circle around her; Catra turns, trying to keep the leader in sight. She feels cornered in a way that she hasn't since Prime's ship, surrounded and outnumbered by enemies too sinister to name.

"Get away from me," she hisses, aiming a kick at one of the jackals. It falls back, yelping, and the rest of them start barking in protest. "Where did you come from, anyway?"

"Peace, traveler," says a deep voice. "They are with me."

A tall, lean man steps forward, the mist dissolving around him as if it has no hold on his movements. His eyes glow dark amber, and his skin is a rich, dark brown. By all appearances he looks to be about as old as Catra, but she senses an ageless quality to him, as if he dwells beyond the reach of time - and although he's breathing and speaking, there's something about him that doesn't quite seem alive. A shiver runs through Catra.

She eyes him warily. "Who are you?"

The man waves his hand, and the jackals fall into line next to him. "Anubis," he says. "Son of Set, right hand of Osiris, prince of death. I come bearing a warning."

Catra stares at him, but his expression is a perfect blank slate: nothing revealed, everything denied. “What warning?”

Anubis spreads his arms out, the mist dispelling at the touch of his hand. “You are in the land of the dead,” he says. “Yet you still live. This is no place for you. You have no idea what dangers lie ahead. You should turn back while you still can; there is too much at stake here. You could lose everything.”

Catra can’t help it; she throws back her head and laughs. The prince of the dead watches her with sorrowful eyes, but Catra can’t see what he has to mourn. He speaks of a loss that she has already experienced, one that’s brought her to devastating ruin, one that she would live and die and beg on bended knee to undo.

“I’ve already lost her,” Catra says bitterly. “What more could I possibly lose?”

Anubis laughs pityingly, the sound harsh and grating against the deathly stillness of the air. “Oh, child,” he says. “If that is truly your way of thinking, then you know nothing of the world. There is always more to lose.”

One of the jackals at his feet barks, and Catra flinches, but Anubis doesn’t blink. He just studies her with those weary amber eyes, and Catra can swear that she sees whole empires rising and falling in the reflections of his irises.

“Do you know where Adora is?” she asks.

“Yes and no,” Anubis answers. “Her soul is in flux. Is it here - or there?” He tilts his head to one side. “She is not entirely beyond us, but she will be soon. But *you* should not be the one to reach her.”

“Listen,” Catra says impatiently. “I don’t have time to stand around talking to you. If you know where Adora is or how I can get her back, then tell me right now. Otherwise, get out of my fucking way.”

The jackals growl softly, eyes glaring a warning at Catra. This time, she doesn't flinch.

"I will take you to the Hall of Judgement," Anubis says finally. "I would deny you passage if I could, but it is not my place to decide." He turns and walks away, and Catra follows without hesitation.

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They travel quickly through the mist, Anubis leading without ever looking back. Catra trails in his wake, noticing that he leaves no footprints behind him; he glides over the sand as though he isn't truly there. And maybe he's not - Catra is no longer sure of what's real and what's only in her head. She remembers distantly, as if it happened years ago, Entrapta's words about the underworld: *there's no way of knowing what's down there, and it's not a place for living beings. We're not made to survive there.*

Catra shrugs it off. She doesn't need to survive this. She just needs to make sure that Adora does.

"Here," Anubis announces. Catra looks up to see a towering pyramid rising above them, pale yellow sandstone blotting out the red of the sky. The point of the capstone is barely visible, hidden behind a vermillion cloud. The sheer immensity of it all is breathtaking; Catra searches for words, finds none.

Anubis steps forward, pressing his palm against the side of the pyramid. A hidden latch clicks, and a high triangular door swings open to reveal a darkened hallway. He gestures to Catra, allowing her to go first.

With an uncomfortable sense that she's walking into her own tomb, Catra steps over the threshold of the pyramid.

Once she's inside, the darkness falls away. The atrium spreads out before her like a kingdom, the starry ceiling thousands of feet above her head, the walls high slabs of obsidian that shine brightly in the light of a thousand burning braziers below. The

other end of the hall is so far away that it's barely visible; the center is supported by four massive sandstone pillars polished to a high shine.

It reminds her, Catra realizes with an unpleasant jolt, of the room on Mystacor where the failsafe for the Heart was once kept. The memory simmers uncomfortably at the edge of her mind; she half expects to see Adora stumbling out from between the pillars with First One's writing glowing forth from her chest.

She grits her teeth, forces herself to focus. Adora isn't here.

Between the pillars, a shallow set of steps leads upwards to a raised dais, where an ornately carved black and gold throne and a golden set of scales rest against the vermillion tiles. A dark, winged creature lies curled and sleeping at the base of the scales; sitting on the throne is a man with blue skin, a strangely shaped crown resting on his head.

"Lord Osiris," Anubis whispers to Catra. "Show him respect." Then, louder: "My lord, I bring you a petitioner from beyond the river."

Osiris fixes Catra with a steady gaze. "I am Osiris, god of the dead," he says. "Approach, seeker, and ask." His tone is measured, devoid of any discernible emotion. Catra suppresses a surge of unease.

"I'm looking for Adora," she says, staring up at him. "My - my friend."

The word *friend* catches in her throat, sounding awkward and inadequate. It feels like too small a word to describe Adora, too superficial to define all that she is to Catra. Adora is a star, a planet, the center of the universe; she's the tide that Catra's moon follows, the gravity that Catra's earth obeys. Adora is the only person that Catra's ever trusted, and she's the only person that Catra's *ever* loved; her love for Adora is a thing of eternity, an aching, bone-deep devotion that lives in every chamber and corner of her heart.

Friend doesn't really cover that.

"Your friend," Osiris muses, thoughtful. "This Adora, she means something to you?"

It's said lightly, genuinely - there's no edge to his voice, but the question rings familiar anyway. It's a callback, an echo of an earlier moment; Catra blinks and suddenly she's back on Prime's ship, digging her claws into the table as she desperately tries to conceal her emotions. The flashbacks start crowding behind her eyelids, and she blinks them away quickly.

"Yes," she says, her voice swallowed by the vastness of the hall. "She does."

Osiris holds out a hand, beckoning her closer. Catra walks forward slowly, climbing the steps of the dais until they're standing barely two feet apart. Up close, Osiris' skin is the clear blue of a summer sky.

"First I will judge you," Osiris says. "Then I will decide whether or not you have earned the help of the Lord of the Dead."

He stretches a hand towards Catra, curling his fingers in the air. Catra watches in detached fascination as a trail of smoke emerges from her chest, morphing into the shape of a heart; she can see it beating, blood passing through red and blue valves, contracting and expanding like the universe.

Osiris waves his hand, and the ghostly heart flies through the air to rest in the cup on one side of the golden scales. A pale white feather sits in the cup on the other side. Catra stares, her heartbeat loud in her throat, as the scales start to move; they shake back and forth for a minute, lifting and then dropping and lifting again, until they settle into perfect balance.

"Interesting," Osiris says, more to himself than to Catra. The winged creature beneath the scales lifts its head and growls softly, and Osiris lifts a finger to quiet it.

“Well?” Catra snaps, wrapping an arm around her stomach as if to protect herself. She feels vulnerable, stripped down to the very marrow of her being; she thinks that if anyone were to look at her right now, they’d be able to see to the center of her soul, and she hates it.

Osiris looks at her, his eyes full of a bottomless melancholy. “You may pass,” he says, his voice the sonorous peal of a church bell at a funeral. “But there is a price.”

“I don’t care,” Catra says. “Whatever it is, I’ll pay it.”

Osirirs shakes his head sadly, then waves a hand once more. The air shimmers in front of her, slowly fading into brightness, and Catra blinks in confusion, tries to look through the glare; the hall is vanishing around her, breaking into shards of stone and light -

The Hall of Judgement disappears. The world goes dark, spinning Catra out into the strands of time.

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(Catra crouches on the floor of the ship, her back pressed against the edge of the captain’s chair. The quiet hum of the engine fills the room, a steady rhythm that flows like a mechanical lullaby. Outside the ship, space stretches out as far as the eye can see, lit by the pale silver shine of the stars that stretch endlessly into the vast darkness.

Bow and Glimmer and Entrapta and Adora have all gone to bed, but Catra can’t sleep. Every time she closes her eyes, she sees Prime’s ship again: the flash of green lights, the harshness of the sheer white walls. The haunting refrains of Prime’s chants play over and over in her ears, the words trapped in her mind like birds in a net. *Cast out the shadows. All beings must suffer to become pure.*

She doesn’t know if she’ll ever be able to sleep again.

She goes to run a hand through her hair, but it's almost gone; her fingers meet the coarse, bristling remains of it. She remembers Prime hacking it off, his eyes full of a demonic kind of pleasure as he tore her apart piece by piece.

Catra remembers and remembers and *remembers* . She wishes she didn't.

She hugs her knees to her chest, whispering to herself, trying to anchor herself. "You're on Adora's ship," she mumbles. "Adora came back for you. Adora saved you."

Did she? Prime's voice answers, his scornful laughter echoing in the back of her mind. *Surely you must be dreaming, little sister. Adora would never come back for you. You are not worth the trouble.*

"Stop," Catra says, pressing her hands against her ears. "You're not here, you're gone, *please just be gone - "*

"Catra?"

Catra's head jerks up; she glances around the room, terrified and expecting the worst.

"Hey, it's okay," Adora says, holding her hands out slowly. "It's just me." She eases herself into a sitting position, leaving space between the two of them, and Catra allows herself to exhale.

"You should be resting," Adora says.

Catra shifts one shoulder forward. "Couldn't sleep."

"Oh," Adora says, nodding. "Yeah, I understand. I'm not surprised. I wouldn't be able to either, if I'd - well, you know."

Catra sneaks a glance at Adora, taking her in. Adora's hair is hanging loose around her shoulders, the same way it was earlier; her eyes are dark with exhaustion, and her mouth is creased in

worry. A bruise blooms on her cheek, a memento from her battle with Prime's clones. She looks tired and battered, but real.

Catra is suddenly gripped with fear, scared that her mind is playing tricks on her again, terrified that it's all another illusion. She reaches out and touches Adora's hand, wrapping her fingers around Adora's until it starts to hurt.

Adora is flesh and blood and bone, solid beneath Catra's touch. Catra lets out a broken sigh of relief.

"Sorry," she mutters. Although it's her second in as many days, the apology still feels unnatural in her mouth. "I just - I wasn't sure if you were real or not."

It sounds stupid the moment the words are out of her mouth, but Adora doesn't laugh. She gently curls her fingers, moving them slowly until they're interlaced with Catra's.

"I'm real," Adora says. "You're here. This is real."

Catra closes her eyes, letting Adora's touch bind her to this moment. It's the first time in years that they've held hands, and she's imagined it a hundred times during the war, wished for it with a reckless kind of yearning that she'd never managed to fully suppress, but she never thought it would happen this way.

Prime's voice again, rolling through her mind like thunder: *Little sister, you are so naive. Is this really how it happens?*

Yes, Catra thinks; *yes, this is how it happens. I'm here. I'm safe. I'm -*

"Are you okay?" Adora asks softly.

Catra opens her eyes slowly, and meets Adora's gaze. They watch each other for a moment, blue and yellow against grey; Adora's eyes are filled with concern, and something softer that Catra can't parse.

“I’m fine,” Catra says, and they both know she’s lying, but the contradiction goes unspoken. With an effort, she turns her head back towards the stars. Something stirs in the back of her mind, rising through green flashes and cold steel.

“You told me about the stars once, didn’t you?” she asks.

Adora nods. “I didn’t know they were real,” she answers. “But they are. They’re right there.”

Catra stares up at the tiny pinpricks of light scattered across the sky until her eyes burn with the hot sting of tears. She swipes a hand roughly across her face, trying not to let Adora see.

“Do you want me to leave?” Adora asks quietly, and this is where Catra should say *yes, leave me alone,* but she doesn’t; she doesn’t want to be alone anymore. She never did.

“No,” she says, barely more than a whisper. “Please. Stay.”

“Okay,” Adora murmurs. “I’ll stay.” She moves forward slowly until their arms are touching, the barest hint of contact flashing between them, and Catra doesn’t flinch away. As they sit together in silence, watching the stars pass by, Catra feels something broken slowly starting to heal.)

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The world rushes in again, and Catra shakes her head, disoriented. She’s in the Hall of Judgement once more, standing at the foot of the dais steps and staring at Osiris. She’s still thinking of a sleepless night, a spaceship, Adora -

Adora, touching her hand - or was she holding it? their fingers interlaced? - and telling her something, something about stars -

Catra’s thoughts scatter, slipping between the cracks as she tries to catch them. She can’t remember what she was thinking of. She reaches and reaches, but the memory isn’t there.

“What did you do,” Catra says, panic twisting in her stomach. *“What did you do?”*

“I told you there would be a price,” Osiris says. He locks eyes with her, his gaze unwavering, unyielding; Catra realizes, too late, the terrible mistake she has made. No matter how long she stares it in the face, death will never blink first.

Osiris reaches for a staff leaning against his throne, uses it to draw a rectangular shape in the air. A door of darkness appears in front of Catra, a hazy obsidian portal that hovers between them like the border between worlds.

“Go on, C’yra,” Osiris says, and Catra barely has time to register the unfamiliar name that he uses for her. “I wish I could help you more.”

“Can’t you?” Catra asks bitterly. “You’re a god.”

Osiris shakes his head, his eyes full of sadness. “Some things,” he says, “are beyond even the gods.”

He flicks his fingers towards the portal; it pulls Catra closer, and suddenly she’s falling through the doorway of the dead.

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(THE SECOND GATE)

Catra is standing in a field.

The sky is slate grey, low clouds hanging above the horizon. The field stretches out for miles in every direction, stalks of wheat and

barley rising to knee height all around her. There's no wind; not even the slightest breeze stirs the grasses.

Catra looks around, taking stock of her surroundings. To the south, past the field, is a barren stretch of ground marked sporadically by patches of fire that burn against the dirt. She can see the shapes of people outlined against the flames, and when she listens closely, the sound of faint screaming fills the air.

She flattens her ears, turns away.

To the east, the land dips downwards in a gentle slope: there's a lake at the bottom, with three small islands in the center. The islands are bathed in golden light, and the waters around them are a perfect, glittering aquamarine; the entire lake is a fragment of paradise in the midst of perdition, misplaced and alone. Catra stares at it longingly, wishing she could go there, but something makes her certain that she can't.

Adora could, she thinks with an unwavering conviction. The islands are a place for heroes, for saviors; if anyone belongs there, Adora does.

Catra looks to the north: a pair of iron gates stand tall, their locks securely bolted. Behind them, a river rushes past, the water a pitch black torrent that makes Catra shiver just from looking at it.

To the west, the fields rise until they become foothills, yielding to a mountain range. The mountains are dark purple peaks topped with white, and at the foot of range sits a palace made of a stone so purely black that it seems as if the entire building has been made from nighttime.

There's a rustling noise, and Catra whips around, searching for a threat. A translucent grey figure pushes past her, the grasses parting in their wake.

"Hey," Catra says cautiously, wondering if this shadowy being is a ghost, if ghosts can even exist. "Where are you going? Where are we?"

“Judgement…” the spirit says, its voice thin and fragile. “Judged unfairly...unfairly. I must return. I must find justice.” It glides away through the grass, and Catra huries to keep up.

“Stop running away,” she says irritably. “I need answers from you.”

“No answers here…” the ghost whispers. “No answers...none here.”

More ghosts start to appear around Catra: pushing through the field, standing around aimlessly, murmuring among themselves. They all seem lost, drifting through the endlessness as if in search of something that they’ll never find, and it unsettles Catra.

“I guess you’re all useless,” she says to them, the words sounding too loud in the quiet of the field. “Thanks for nothing.”

The ghosts don’t respond. Catra sighs, sets her sights on the palace in the west, and starts walking.

She passes through dozens of ghosts, their protests almost inaudible susurrations in her ears. Blades of grass become flattened and withered beneath her feet, their sharp edges slicing at her ankles - one long strand actually draws blood, parting her skin with the keen precision of a razor. Catra bends down to wipe it away, her fingers staining red as they touch the wound. She shakes the drops from her hand and keeps moving.

It doesn’t feel like she’s getting anywhere, but suddenly the field falls away and she’s standing at the foothills below the palace; distance folds itself in half, bending to her will like a tree in the wind. Catra climbs the foothills on weary legs, each step an exercise in futility - when she finally reaches the top, she feels like she’s made a deal with the devil.

A vast swath of courtyard gardens are laid out before her, miles of unearthly vines and blossoms spreading across black stone tiles. Catra finds a path through the park - a winding track inlaid with streaks of silver - and follows it towards the palace.

Within the gardens, all sound is swallowed by the foliage. Catra can barely see past all the vegetation: thick ropes of ivy cling to the path and the walls, delicate flowers spring up beside the fountains, knotted trees bow beneath the weight of branches laden with unfamiliar fruits. Even though she's surrounded by the growth of a thousand flora, she can't help but feel that none of it is actually alive; despite the abundance of leaves and blossoms, the garden feels like a desolate wasteland, a graveyard built for the living dead.

The path leads Catra to a clearing with yet another fountain at its center. This one is a three-tiered structure shaped from some kind of silver metal, water flowing from tier to tier. It looks perfectly clear and cold, and the dry ache in the back of Catra's throat longs to drink, but she holds herself back. She can't risk even a single sip.

Across the clearing, a grove of gnarled trees spread their shallow roots through the grass. The leaves are so dark green that they're almost black, and the trunks look half-rotted, but there are large round fruits hanging from the branches. They're nothing that Catra's ever seen before, but they're so perfectly crimson that Catra's mouth waters in anticipation.

She crosses the clearing to take one of the fruits, plucking it gently from the branch and digging her claws into it carefully; she's not going to eat any of it, but she just wants to see -

"I wouldn't," someone says.

Catra drops the fruit; it falls to the ground, splitting open upon impact. Red seeds spill across the courtyard like rubies, shining brightly against the obsidian tiles.

"I wasn't going to eat it," she says defensively, more to herself than to whoever is speaking to her. She glances to the right, following the sound of the stranger's voice, and her blood runs cold.

The woman standing by the fountain is tall: taller than Anubis, taller even than She-Ra. She's lean and lithe, her skin a dark shade of mahogany, her hair falling in jet black waves around her delicate shoulders. Her eyes are grey, but they're nothing like Adora's eyes; rather than the warm grey of the sky after rainfall, they're the cold silver of metal that's never seen the light of day. There's a ceremonial robe draped around her shoulders, the fabric a glossy black that glistens with her every move; an iridescent patina plays across the cloth, shifting across the landscape of her body.

Catra looks closer and stifles an exclamation of horror: the cloth seems to be *alive.* The coruscating shine of silver forms screaming faces that break and form and break again, as if the robe has been woven from the souls of the dead, and she can only think of one entity who holds that kind of power.

"Oh, great," she mumbles to herself. "Just what I need. Another god of the dead."

"Careful with your loose words, mortal," the woman says, her tone low and controlled; there's danger in her voice, the breathless beat of an army, the warning call of a siren. "But yes, you are correct. I am Hades, lord of the underworld. If you wish to pass through my domain unscathed, you would be wise to hold your impertinent tongue."

Catra narrows her eyes; this is the god of the dead, the land of the dead, but she's still living. Her hands clench into fists, her claws sliding free.

Perhaps sensing this, Hades looks down on her with a gaze that sweeps over Catra with the icy chill of midwinter frost.

"Come," she says. "We will have tea, and if you are lucky, you will not join my collection of souls."

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They sit on the terrace by the palace doors, the floor beneath them a great expanse of black and silver tiles arranged in flawless diamond patterns. With a single hand gesture, Hades conjures up two chairs and a table made from a polished wood so ancient that it's turned to stone. Catra sits on the edge of her seat, still wary.

"Will you relax?" Hades says, scowling at her. "You living beings are so very...well, *living.* It's irritating."

"Yeah," Catra says dryly. "That's kind of the whole point."

Hades sighs, waving her hand over the table. A game board appears between them, a board of alternating black and white squares with four rows of strange looking pieces resting on the farthest sides of the boards.

"I thought that we could play a game of chance," Hades says pensively. "Would you care to make a wager?"

"I don't deal in chance," Catra answers. "I make my own luck."

"Oh, do you," Hades says, the corner of her mouth quirking upwards in an arrogant smile. "And how's that working out for you?"

She stares at Catra, and her eyes start to change; something flickers in them, resolving into a set of images flashing in the depths of her irises: Prime's ship, Catra falling, her body lying broken on the floor, Adora cradling her limp form…

"Stop it," Catra snarls, ripping her gaze away from Hades' face. "Don't show me that. You think you can tell me anything about how bad my luck is? You think you know my life better than me?" Her fingers dig into the surface of the table, carving deep trenches through the ancient wood. "I know that I've had a bad life. I've been cursed from the moment I was born. The only part of me worth anything is Adora, and that's why I'm here - I didn't come to play your stupid board games or talk about the past. I'm here for Adora, so *give her back to me."*

Hades blinks, and her eyes return to normal. “I suppose it’s for the better that you didn’t want to play,” she says finally, picking up one of the game pieces and rolling it between her fingers. “I always win.”

“Not this time,” Catra says.

Hades places the piece back on the board, in a different square. “Your determination is nothing but delusion,” she says. “Another like you came here once; he asked me for his bride’s soul back, and I agreed, but he lost her anyway through his own shortcoming. Do you really think you can save her? There are some things that you have to let go of.”

“I’m not letting go of her!” Catra says, her voice rising in anger. “It’s easy for you to say I should let go - you don’t know what it’s like to lose anyone. You just sit down here in the underworld collecting soul after soul. You take their lives, and you take their afterlives too - you can’t possibly understand what it’s like to *lose* someone.”

Hades leans forward over the table, her face suddenly a mask of venom. “You are a child,” she hisses. “You know nothing of loss, if you think to cheat it so easily. Do you really think you can keep the ones you love? Everything is temporary.”

She gestures to the plants at the edge of the terrace, pale red blossoms wrapping around stone pillars. “Every six months, my lover leaves me for the world above. We have a half-life, a half-love, a blossom that flowers and withers on the vine over and over again. We find and lose each other with the turn of the seasons; that is the way of life, and death too. You are a fool to think that you can keep her forever. Loving someone just means you will lose them.”

Catra meets her gaze defiantly. “Maybe for you,” she says. “But not for me. Not anymore.”

Hades starts to say something else, but then stops dead, looking over Catra's shoulder. Catra faces the same direction, watching as a trio of old women appear in the shadows at the edge of the palace wall. All three of them look ancient, and Catra feels a thrill of foreboding run through her; she's facing something older than the earth, older than time.

"The Fates," Hades murmurs.

"Go, child of death," the middle Fate says, her voice like the creak of trees in the wind. "Leave us."

Hades nods respectfully and dissolves into a column of black mist, leaving Catra alone on the terrace with Fate itself.

"What do you want from me?" Catra asks, her eyes flicking between the Fates. She's sure that their physical forms would be easy to defeat in a fight, but she's just as sure that any of them could destroy her with a single movement; destiny is the trap, and she's already caught.

"Hmm, yes," the first Fate says. "Familiar, but different. A lifetime in repeat."

"First the poet, searching for his bride," the second Fate says. "Now the lover, searching for her warrior."

The third Fate says nothing. Instead, she pulls a richly woven tapestry from her basket. Catra finds that she can't look directly at it - when she tries, her eyes start to burn.

"Here," the second Fate says, pulling two threads from the center: one gold and one silver, entwined so closely that they seem more one strand than two separate cords. Catra focuses on the two threads, and suddenly a series of moments cascades through her mind.

She's five years old and sleeping next to Adora in a narrow cadet bed; she's eleven years old and sparring with Adora, staffs crossed in stalemate; she's seventeen years old and sitting alone

on the Fright Zone rooftop, staring into the distance and wondering if Adora will ever come home. Catra curls up at her feet; Adora smiles at her. Adora raises her sword; Catra springs at her. The images come faster now, moments of happiness and hatred spilling forth like water, Catra and Adora over and over again; at the beginning, at the end, at all the moments in between.

“Is that - ” Catra starts, choking on the words. Her throat stings, a beehive kicked into flight.

“Yes,” the third Fate says, turning milk-white eyes towards her. “You have always been intertwined. Always - until now.”

“You wish to save her, yes?” says the first Fate. “Ah, a fickle thing.” She cackles, twisting a stray thread around her finger.

“I’m going to save her,” Catra says. “Tell me what I have to do.”

The second Fate sets aside the gold and silver threads. She grasps the string next to them and pulls it.

As the darkness closes in, the last thing Catra sees is the color of the string - it’s a bold, unforgiving red.

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(Catra sits on the rooftop, legs hanging over the edge. Below her, the buildings of the Fright Zone sprawl out beneath her in a jumbled mess of grey and green shapes. Above her, the moon is shining in a pale lavender sky.

She knows that she should be at third drill right now, but she can’t bring herself to join the rest of the cadets, not after what had happened that morning. They’d all been sitting in the mess hall during lunch when Adora came back from a meeting with Shadow Weaver and dropped into her usual seat beside Catra. Catra had glanced over at her, ready to make a joke about how they’d eaten all the grey rations without her, and then -

She had looked at Adora: smiling tiredly but brightly, one golden strand of hair falling loose over her forehead - she'd looked at Adora and her heart had skipped a beat.

She had wanted to reach over and tuck the stray lock of hair behind Adora's ear, wanted it so badly that her chest had started to ache. Her hands - her useless, treacherous hands - had forgotten how to do anything other than reach for Adora. She'd actually been halfway to grabbing Adora's hand before catching herself and fleeing from the table with a hastily muttered excuse.

And then she'd retreated to the rooftop for the rest of the day, because she didn't know what else to do. She's had feelings like this before, on mornings spent sparring and late nights spent whispering together in Adora's bed, but it's never been this strong.

Catra presses one hand to her face, trying to drown out her thoughts. She can fix this. She can forget that she feels anything. She can -

"Hey," a voice says, and Catra's heart stutters again. She turns around to see Adora standing behind her, wearing her red jacket over a standard white Horde uniform shirt, her hair pulled up in its usual messy ponytail. Her eyes are shining brightly, warm and full of life, and she's smiling at Catra.

"I thought you'd be up here," Adora says, sitting down. Their shoulders brush, and Catra leans into the touch before she can second-guess herself. Adora's body is warm against hers, solid and steady, the way it's always been.

Catra pushes her face into Adora's hair and inhales - sweat, metal, a faint hint of sweetness that even the Horde's regulation lye soap has never been able to scrub from Adora's skin. The familiarity of it all makes Catra weak. She'd come up here to be alone, but despite her tangled mess of feelings towards her right now, Adora's company is better than any solitude.

“You’re here,” she manages to say. “Shouldn’t you be off kicking everyone’s ass in combat training? It would be easy today, seeing as I wasn’t there to beat you.”

Adora rolls her eyes. “You beating me? Please. I totally pinned you yesterday. Besides, drills are over now.” She nudges Catra playfully. “Not that you’d know anything about those, seeing as you skipped again. Shadow Weaver was *pissed* .” She pulls something out of her pocket: a ration bar, wrapped in foil. “She said you’d have to miss dinner, but I brought you food anyway.”

Catra takes the bar from her. “Thanks,” she says, unwrapping it. It’s grey, her favorite kind.

“Of course,” Adora answers. She unwraps her own ration bar, and they eat in silence for a moment.

Once they’re done with their dinner, Adora leans back on her hands, tips her head up towards the sky. The moon is full, casting a gentle silver glow over the rooftop; the light clings to Adora’s profile, caresses the line of her jaw. Catra can’t look away.

“Hey,” Adora says affectionately, slinging an arm around Catra’s waist and resting her head against her shoulder. “What are you thinking about? You seemed kind of off today.”

Catra shrugs. “I’m fine. I just don’t want to go back to the bunk room tonight.”

Adora glances at her, a smile curling at the edge of her mouth. “Okay, so then we won’t.” She takes off her jacket and folds it up, then lies on her back and places it under her head. “We can sleep up here tonight. It’s super warm out, we’ll be fine.”

They won’t be fine in the morning if Shadow Weaver catches them, but neither of them mention that.

Catra lies down next to Adora, the jacket soft beneath them. Adora reaches for her hand and squeezes quickly, roughly, one of those touches that walks the line between playful aggression and

genuine affection. Violence is the common method of interaction in the Horde, but Catra and Adora have managed to make it their own; they deal in closeness disguised as conflict, love lingering beneath the surface of every punch and scuffle. Only when they're alone can they let the truth breathe freely.

"You know," Adora says thoughtfully, "one of the older cadets was talking about stars today."

Catra raises an eyebrow. "Stars? What are those?"

"Bright lights in the sky, she said," Adora answers. "Like the moon, but tiny, and there's hundreds of them. Other worlds must have them. They made shapes - constellations, I think, and they all had stories behind them."

"'Bright lights in the sky,'" Catra scoffs, punching Adora lightly on the arm. "You sound insane."

Adora sighs restlessly, shifting around. "There was just something about the story - it almost feels like I've seen them before. Stars, I mean."

"No way," Catra says. "You're out of your head."

Adora just shrugs; she stares wistfully up at the sky, like she's searching for something that never existed. Her lost expression pulls at something deep in Catra's chest, and she searches for something to say, anything that will bring Adora's smile back.

"Hey," she says. "There might not be any stars, but we still have the moon." She pushes her face into the crook of Adora's neck. "Tell me the story behind that."

"Okay," Adora says, smiling again. "The moon may look like it's all alone, but it's not. It has a friend - the sun. The moon and the sun have always been best friends, and their story goes like this. Once upon a time - "

"Adora, what the fuck is a *sun?* "

“A kind of planet-star thing, I think,” Adora says, giving Catra a fond glance. “Now shut up and listen. Don’t you want the story?”

“Okay, fine,” Catra says. She curls up against Adora, inhales deeply. “Go ahead.”

Adora points up at the moon; Catra looks at her hand. She clings to Adora’s side and wishes that this moment could last forever.)

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Catra comes back to herself in bits and pieces, fragments of awareness. She’s standing in front of the Fates once more, and she was just thinking about something - the stars, the moon; a warm feeling of happiness in her chest; a rooftop and a story about the sun -

No, that’s not right. She’s never heard of the sun.

“Such determination,” the first Fate says, a look of rapture spreading across her wizened face. “Even Orpheus was not so persistent.”

The third Fate runs a crooked finger along the edge of a small sewing knife. “We are agreed, then?”

“We are.”

The second Fate picks up the gold and silver strings, raising them to the light. The third Fate brings the knife to the place where they join the tapestry: blade pressed to thread, destiny splitting beneath the touch of metal.

It’s as if the knife is piercing Catra, too; with an agonized cry, she lunges forward, desperate to stop them, desperate to save herself, desperate to save Adora.

She hits the tapestry face first, and it yields beneath her, fabric turning to the fluid currents of time -

The night spreads out before her. Catra drowns in its embrace.

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(THE THIRD GATE)

A hall materializes around Catra, surrounding her with the glow of lacquered oak and polished bronze.

It's the largest building that she's ever set foot in; the Hall of Judgement pales in comparison. The ceiling is nearly a mile high, the rafters built from an interweaving lattice of spears, and the walls are covered in round shields made from bronze burnished to a dull shine.

Catra looks around slowly, her brain struggling to make sense of the immensity of it all. Nothing in the hall feels quite normal: there's an element of impossibility that clings to the edges, blurring the lines.

In one corner of the room, an immense tree grows straight from the floor, its massive branches spreading up through the ceiling. Terraced rows of seats descend all around the hall, long oak dining tables stretching out before each one. At the far end of the hall, an elevated table sits before a massive throne, empty except for two ravens perched on its arms. Light streams down through the ceiling's latticework of spears, dappling the floor in the pale yellow glare of midwinter sun.

As Catra stands in the center of the room, still processing the sheer magnitude of its splendor, the air starts to shimmer like heat waves in the desert. Figures appear in the rows of seats, on the floor; they're nothing but shadowy silhouettes at first, but they slowly become solid, colors bleeding into their shapes until the

hall is full of sound. Most of them slide into the seats, while a small group of fierce looking women fly around the hall, calling to each other, joking with the sitting ones.

They're not just people, Catra realizes, her gaze catching on signs of war: blades tucked beneath belts, knuckles bruised from fighting, scars tracing skin like moonlight on water. They're soldiers. They're warriors.

No two of them look alike, but they're unmistakably bound by a common strand; they share a camaraderie built from the bones of battle, kindred spirits forged in flame. It's subtle, but Catra can see it clear as day; it's the kind of bond she used to share with the cadets in the Horde.

It's the kind of bond that she used to share with Adora.

Catra watches with an ache in her chest, feeling like she's standing in someone else's memory. Even though she can hear shouts and laughs, even though she can see the bright eyes and confident smiles of the warriors, they don't seem to be quite there. It's as if there are two realities stacked on top of each other, ghosts in a garden in spring, humans in a graveyard in winter. None of them seem to see Catra; their eyes shift past her as if she's not there. She thinks, with a stomach-tightening pang of dread, that maybe she's the ghost.

A man appears on the throne, tall and white-haired, a dark patch covering his left eye. In his hand is a long golden spear, which he bangs against the floor to get the attention of the hall.

"People of Valhalla," he announces in a baritone voice that reaches to the rafters. "Our battles today were glorious. Many of our warriors gained much honor for themselves. As Odin, the Allfather, the All-Knower, I give you my word: we grow ever stronger in preparation for Ragnarok."

The warriors cheer in response, a deafening rush of sound that pours forth with the triumphant crash of waves against cliffs; it's

the center of the ocean, and a storm is coming. Catra wonders if she'll be swept along with it.

"And," Odin continues, once quiet falls again, "we have another cause to celebrate tonight. A new warrior comes to join our cause."

The hall goes still, the air a bated breath caught between the lungs of the world; the crowd turns in a ripple of movement, looking to where Odin points. Catra follows their gaze to the person approaching the table in front of the throne, and she stops breathing.

Adora stands before the throne, her hair loose and flowing around her shoulders, her sword strapped to her back. The sight of her burns like a star in Catra's chest, her heartbeat racing past the sound barrier, every cell in her body hovering on the verge of explosion. She feels like a supernova.

She tries to speak, but the words won't come; she stands frozen in time, frozen in silence, frozen on the edge of the universe as Adora steps into the light.

"Adora," Odin says, turning his one-eyed gaze upon her. "You died valiantly, with a weapon in your hand. In return, I offer you a place in Valhalla, the hall of fallen heroes."

Don't do it, Catra wants to scream, but her voice still won't work.

Adora looks up at him, eyes wide. "I'm honored," she says, "but - "

"You will never want for anything," Odin says. "You will never die again, as long as you live with us. You will be invincible, all-powerful. You will be honored beyond belief. Is there anyone in the nine worlds who could offer you better?"

I could, Catra wants to say, but she can't; she has nothing to offer Adora except shared trauma and a lifetime of worthless devotion.

She has no right or reason to expect Adora to stay. After all, she never has before.

Catra thinks of Adora leaving over and over, abandoning her time and time again. She thinks of Adora turning away from her, turning her back: *You made your choice, now live with it.* She thinks -

She thinks of Adora, bent over her, one hand pressed to her cheek: *You matter to me.*

Just like that, Catra's voice breaks free, ripping from her throat in a desperate cry. It's a single word, but it's the only one that matters.

"Adora!"

She half expects Adora not to hear, half expects that Adora will look straight through her, but she doesn't; Adora turns, searching for her, the rest of the world falling away as they lock eyes.

"Catra?" Adora stares at her. "You're here?"

"Adora," Catra says again, like it's the only name she's ever learned, and maybe it is. "Adora, wait." She can't move. She can't breathe. She can't look at anything besides Adora. The hall is silent, the crowd of warriors slowly fading, the colors bleaching away. Odin remains, one hand wrapped around his spear, contemplation written across his face.

"You may stay, too, if you want," he says, nodding to Catra as if seeing her for the first time. "I would not dream of separating you."

Catra's heart jumps into her throat, hope carving a hollow space beneath her ribs. She wants - she *wants* . They may never return home if they stay here, but she can think of nothing better than a lifetime with Adora; wherever she is will become home to Catra.

Adora smiles at her, holding out a hand. "Coming?"

Catra reaches forward, their fingers inches from touching; the room begins to shift, the edges rounding, sliding into curves, space rushing into the distance between her and Adora as a silver vapor fills the air.

“Adora!” Catra cries again, and the room disappears.

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The first thing that Catra notices is the cold.

It’s a bitter, biting cold, a cold that climbs inside her bones and settles within the marrow. It’s a cold that crawls in her veins, blood turning to ice; her chest a snowglobe, her mouth a frozen wound. It’s a cold that tears her apart from the inside out.

She’s standing in a cave of ice. The ceiling is a forest of razor sharp icicles; the walls are rimed with hoarfrost, glittering like diamonds. Outside the cave, the sky is a dark grey expanse of clouds heavy with snow.

Hovering near the cave wall is a shimmering sphere of something pale and clear, and inside it, Catra can see the hall of Valhalla; it’s painted in a hazy wash of pastel colors, waning into obscurity. She sees Adora framed by a shaft of golden light, her face open and unsure, her forehead lined with concern and a stray strand of hair falling over her left eye; Catra reaches for the sphere, hands trembling, fear and hope rising in her like a tidal wave.

Just as her fingers are about to make contact, the sphere flies away from her, drifting towards the back of the cave.

“Well, well,” says a voice, and it’s even colder than the weather; it’s a voice that breaks like ice shattering against barren ground. Catra can feel her chest freezing, frost gripping her heart, a sense of foreboding descending around her shoulders like snowfall.

When she sees the woman who’s talking, the rest of Catra’s body turns to ice as well.

“Yes,” the woman says, extending her hand. The sphere sails towards her, a tiny world resting in the palm of her hand, and she holds it up to the watery blue light with a pensive expression. “What a beautiful dream.”

“There, there,” the woman says, smiling coldly. “You didn’t think you were really *there* , did you? Oh, little cat, you *so* amuse me. As if you would ever be accepted in the halls of Valhalla. No, you belong down here with us; the lost, the hated, the destroyers of light.” She spreads out her arms expressively, a great theatrical gesture that follows the sweep of a glacier. “After all, don’t you think we are something alike? Look at me.”

Catra looks, and in her horror, she cannot look away.

The woman is tall and thin, so thin that Catra can see her ribs arching forward underneath her robe. Her skin is a pale ivory, the color of bones bleached bare in the sun; her hair falls in waves of pale gold, so fine that it almost vanishes under the light. Half of her is covered completely in frost, the division running right down the center of her being: her left arm formed from masterfully wrought ice, the left side of her face a mask of rime, the entire left side of her body a blinding mess of white and silver cold. It sends chills down Catra’s spine, and not just because of the sub-zero temperature; it reminds her of when she was in the portal, a reflection of herself that she hates to see.

“Stop that,” Catra says, her claws sliding out instinctively. “Stop mocking me.”

“Dear cat,” the woman says, her tone sliding into sickly sweet condescension, “I'm not *mocking* you. Haven’t you heard that old adage? Imitation, flattery, something about sincerity - we’ve all said it a thousand times.” She shrugs, the movement sending flakes of snow cascading down around her.

“Besides,” she continues. “We have other things to discuss. Don’t you want to know who I am?”

“I already know who you are,” Catra snarls. “You’re a giant bitch made of ice who’s going to get smacked down in about two seconds if you don’t give me Adora back.” Her hands clench into fists, so hard that her claws draw blood from her own skin; it drips down her fingers, its copper sting a quickly stifled flame of heat in this land of cold. Scarlet drops fall to the cave floor, painting red across white.

“Well, you could call me that,” the woman muses. “I’ve heard worse. But to give me my full title…” She spins the sphere that still sits at her fingertips, so fast that its image is blurred beyond discernment. “I am Hela, the goddess of death, ruler of Helheim. I would warn you though: do *not* confuse me with those other paltry death gods you met before. Osiris is *such* a bore, and Hades - well, she tries, but she’s awfully morbid, don’t you think? Moping around doing nothing but missing her wife... *honestly* . Endless grief is so passé.”

Hela’s pale blue eyes shining with a fanatical gleam. Catra looks into their depths, thinks of falling through a frozen river; there’s a life to be lost here, drowned beneath the brutal weight of the currents.

“I am not just the goddess of death,” Hela continues, the words ringing through the cave now. “I am the infinite embrace of night. I swallow life, kill flame with frost; I gather the souls of mortals and seal them away, entombed in ice forever. My touch brings eternal sleep, or some other utterly saccharine thing of that nature. I am death itself , and you are a brokenhearted lover with blood on your hands. So I ask you: who are you to challenge me?”

More blood drips down Catra’s hand. This is a fight that Catra should walk away from, but she’s never been one to pick her battles.

“I’m Catra,” she says, and for just a moment, her voice is as loud as Hela’s; it carries the same gravity, echoing of devotion instead of death, a funeral dirge turned battle hymn. “I’m a screwup and

a disaster and I've never done one good thing in my life before this week, and I want Adora back."

"Ah, yes," Hela says, a sly smile creeping over her face. "Adora. Your companion, your best friend. The person closest to your heart. To paraphrase one of the modern prophets, it's always been just her and you together, hasn't it? And when she walks in..."

Another dream sphere appears at her fingertips, spinning slowly this time; Catra catches a glimpse of grey metal walls, dusty floors, a dimly lit storeroom that feels all too familiar -

"Show me," Hela says, and she sends the sphere flying towards Catra. The second it touches her skin, she's gone.

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(Catra curls beneath a blanket in the storeroom, pressed against the cold metal floor, her eyes tightly closed. Her body aches, and her head aches too. She feels like every bone in her body is bruised.

She rests her bruised forehead against the scratchy fabric of the blanket, forcing herself to replay the events that brought her here.

Fifty minutes earlier, she had been eating dinner with the other cadets and everything had been normal; Lonnie had been throwing pieces of ration bar at Kyle, and Rogelio and Adora had been laughing. Adora's arm had been pressed against Catra's as they rested on the table, and Catra had felt content and happy.

Forty minutes earlier, that moment of peaceful normality had been shattered as Shadow Weaver entered the room and grabbed Catra, dragging her away from the table to interrogate her about something that had been stolen from her rooms. Catra didn't know anything about it, but Shadow Weaver hadn't accepted that; Adora had tried to defend her, but Shadow Weaver had brushed her off like a troublesome fly.

Thirty-five minutes earlier, Shadow Weaver had led Catra into one of the training rooms and demanded that Catra return the things that had gone missing, and when Catra had said that she didn't know what was going on - *"I don't know what you're talking about, I didn't go near your dumb room"* - Shadow Weaver hadn't accepted it. Instead, she had pulled the shadows from the corners of the room and wrapped them around Catra, choking her, blocking out the light as she slowly pressed the air from Catra's lungs. Catra had fallen to the ground, dizzy; she had been vaguely aware of Shadow Weaver kicking her in the ribs.

Thirty minutes earlier, Adora had shown up in the doorway, begging for Shadow Weaver to stop, distracting her long enough for Catra to get to her feet and run.

That's how she found herself in this storeroom in the back of the Fright Zone, hiding beneath a blanket and nursing her wounds. She's too stunned and hurt to do anything except slowly breathe, but even existing feels like an act of defiance against Shadow Weaver.

The door opens with a squeak of rusty hinges, and Catra shrinks back, hoping that whoever's out there won't see her. She closes her eyes tightly, tensing in preparation to run again.

The blanket is pulled gently off her head, and Catra bares her teeth, hissing in protest; her eyes remain shut tight, narrowed to slits.

"Catra, it's okay," Adora says, and Catra relaxes into the familiar sound of her voice. "It's just me."

Tears sting at the corner of Catra's eye, running over before she can hide them. Adora reaches for her, resting one hand on top of Catra's own, the touch comforting and gentle.

"It doesn't matter what they do to us, you know?" Adora says. "You look out for me, and I look out for you. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other."

“You promise?” Catra asks, and it’s like handing Adora her heart; she’s laid bare, all her cards on the table, everything she’s ever been too scared to hope for suddenly spilling out in a rush. Later, when she looks back on this moment, she’ll think that maybe the whole of her being was built from the foundation of this promise.

“I promise,” Adora answers. She slips her hand into Catra’s, lacing their fingers together, and Catra allows herself to breathe. For this one moment, she’s found peace.)

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“No,” Catra says, her breaths coming raggedly. She’s on the floor of the cave, curled up and shivering, tears freezing on her face. She presses her hands to the ground, forces herself to stand. “No, you can’t have that one, you can’t - ”

It’s too late; the memory’s gone. There’s nothing left of it in Catra’s mind but the vague shape of a promise she can’t remember making.

“Such agony,” Hela says, her face shadowed by a dark kind of pleasure. “Simply delicious.”

“You’re sick,” Catra says, rage boiling like lava beneath her skin.

“Maybe so,” Hela replies, looking positively delighted at this assessment of her character. “But I have something you want.” She raises a hand, and the cave fills with dream spheres, fragments of a thousand lives hovering in the wintry air. Catra’s gaze sweeps over them, gathering different glimpses: Bow and Glimmer, sitting in the Bright Moon war room; Mermista and Perfuma, standing in the castle garden together; Scorpia alone in her room, crying as she stares at a picture of herself and Catra.

Catra stares hungrily at the images, drinking them in. It’s as if she’s seeing a past life, ghosts from a place she used to live.

Hela holds out her hand, and one more dream sphere appears: Adora, trapped in a sea of golden light and static, her expression

lost and frightened. It's a knife to Catra's chest.

"I could give you what you want most," Hela says, her tone silky smooth, poison mixed with wine. "I could return Adora to life. But I would need something good in return."

Catra crosses her arms, more to keep herself warm than to seem defiant. "Fine. What do you want?"

Hela's eyes bore into Catra, cold and ancient, the icy blue of a lifeless winter. Catra swears she can feel death hovering over her head like a naked sword blade.

"I won't ask for much," Hela says, her mouth curled into a mirthless smirk. "I'm thinking that your soul would be a fair trade."

Catra's mouth goes dry.

"What's wrong?" Hela croons. "Won't you take this bargain? Or would you not sacrifice yourself for her salvation, if you knew that you would never reap the reward?"

Catra would make that sacrifice - she's made it once before, onboard Prime's ship. Adora had still come to save her then, but she won't be able to again. This time, when Catra puts her own head in the noose, there will be no one to cut the rope.

But Adora will be saved, and that's all that matters.

"I will," Catra says. There's fear drowning her chest, lungs filling with water, but she pushes it down; she thinks once more of Adora, limned in gold, smile brighter than the full moon. "I'll make the sacrifice. You can have my stupid soul."

Hela smiles widely, her mouth a slant of cruelty; she steps forward, extending her ice arm. Catra braces herself for an eternity of cold.

“Stop,” says a voice from the mouth of the cave, and it holds so much authority that Hela freezes like the ice she’s made of.

For a moment, Catra can’t breathe.

The woman in the doorway is as tall as Hela, shining with the same aureate glow that Adora does in Catra’s memory, her clothing the familiar white and gold of She-Ra’s armor. The sword in her hand is a blade that Catra knows better than the back of her hand. For one weightless second, Catra is convinced that Adora’s back, that she’s here somehow -

“Oh, good,” Hela says disdainfully. “A washed up has-been of a hero. Just what this party needs.”

The woman steps forward into the cave, and the magic fades; her skin is dark where Adora’s is light, her hair paler than Adora’s, her eyes warm blue instead of stormy grey. But she wields the Sword of Protection with the same deadly grace, and as she points it at Hela, her grip on the hilt is as strong as Adora’s ever was.

A name springs to Catra’s mind: *Mara.* Adora’s predecessor.

“So I’m not She-Ra anymore,” Mara says, clear and strong. “I accept that. I yielded that title many years ago, but I will take it up once again to defend the one it belongs to now.”

Hela draws herself up with murderous rage in her eyes. “You are not permitted to intervene. The girl has given her soul freely.”

“I disagree,” Mara says. “Your reign has gone on too long, goddess of death. I’m here to take you down a few pegs.”

Hela flicks a finger; a knife-sharp icicle shoots forward towards Catra, but Mara slashes it out of the air faster than Catra can feel any fear. Mara stands between her and Hela, defending her without fear, and Catra squints, disoriented; it’s as if she sees Adora standing in Mara’s place, the two of them occupying the same space of protection.

“Enough,” Mara says. “ *Enough* .” She strikes her sword against the ground, and the cave walls start to crumble, melting and falling to pieces around them.

Hela screams in rage, raising her arms; dream spheres push forward, multiplying, filling the cave even as the walls collapse. Catra scrambles backwards, narrowly avoiding them, as the light starts to die.

Someone grabs her arm: Mara, fingers tight around her skin.

“I’ll hold her off,” Mara says, lit by the glow of the sword’s runestone. “You go save Adora.”

An icicle crashes down next to them, ice chips shattering like shrapnel. The wind picks up, howling around the cave in an eerie song of death; the temperature drops sharply, turning Catra numb.

“I was going to,” Catra says, the words clumsy in her freezing mouth. “Hela offered me…”

“No,” Mara says. “That wasn’t the way to save her. This isn’t how it happens.” She reaches for a dream sphere, pulls it towards them; a starburst of rainbow light fills it, half-blinding Catra. “Cross the bridge. Find her.”

“But you - ”

“I won’t die,” Mara says. “I’m already dead.”

The ceiling gives way, crashing down around them, a thousand tons of frozen death descending; Mara pushes the dream sphere into Catra’s hands and the world shifts around her, exploding into a kaleidoscope of colors that turn into a blinding wash of white light. Catra feels herself being pulled towards the sky, gravity acting in reverse, flying free from the damage as the cave explodes beneath her.

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(THE FOURTH GATE)

Catra lands on a hard surface, the impact sending bolts of pain searing through her legs. She straightens up slowly and carefully, brushing remnants of ice from her arms, and then she sees where she is and the bottom of her stomach is in freefall, because she's standing -

She's standing in the center of the sky.

A bridge stretches out before her, seven brightly colored arcs of pure light bent into a rainbow pathway through the heavens. A sheen of iridescence plays across its surface like moonlight on water, giving the unsettling illusion that it's not quite solid. Catra bends down and presses her hand against its firm surface, just to make sure.

Behind her, the gold-tiered towers of Valhalla rise into the blue expanse. Catra longs, for a moment, to run back across the bridge and burst into the hall in search of Adora, but she knows it won't succeed. The vision of Adora in the hall was just that - a vision.

Before her, the bridge stretches out to the horizon before dipping low and disappearing in a dull grey bank of soft-edged clouds. There's a smear of golden light painted across the skyline, far ahead of her, and Catra fixes her eyes upon it. She knows, somehow, that it marks the place she needs to reach.

She starts walking.

Time passes the same way it has since she entered the underworld: it moves in starts and stops, twisting and turning, doubling back on itself, forming braided strands and loops without end or beginning. Hours melt into years, centuries becoming

minutes; nothing is linear, nothing has meaning. Catra can't recall when she started this journey; it could have been yesterday, it could have been a lifetime ago. It unnerves her.

She tries to ignore it, focusing instead on the bridge instead. It's so beautiful it almost hurts to look at, and it's smooth and solid beneath her feet, but there's a certain otherworldly quality to it besides just its dazzling color. If Catra concentrates hard, it's as if she can feel the touch of other worlds pressing up all around her, like she could fall into another universe if she leaned too far over the side. She's almost tempted to try; she's sure that if she did, she'd find Adora somehow. Catra would cross every universe in existence if there was even a chance that Adora was waiting on the other side.

She walks on, her eyes beginning to blur from the brightness of the bridge. There are images flickering in the air at the edges of the bridge, dancing in the peripherals of Catra's vision, but they always disappear when Catra tries to look at them directly. Maybe, she thinks, they're glimpses of those other worlds.

She moves towards the left side of the bridge, determined to get a better look at one image that flashes gold and silver against a black background, and she's so busy staring that she doesn't notice the bridge is ending.

The rainbow light disappears from beneath her, yielding to a crooked mess of wooden slats latticed between two rickety rope handrails. Catra falls forward onto the planks, splinters pushing into her hands as she tries to break her fall.

"You've got to be kidding me," she mumbles, pulling a splinter from her palm as she slowly gets to her feet again. "Can't you change back to the rainbow part?"

The bridge remains as it is: splintery and annoying. Catra sighs and pushes onwards.

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The wooden bridge is a thousand times worse than the rainbow bridge.

Catra hates walking on it. She's used to smooth surfaces beneath her feet, whether the metal floors of the Fright Zone or the worn dirt of Etheria's various roads and paths, but the splintery boards of this bridge are nothing like either of those; they're all broken slivers and sharp angles, calculated to leave their mark on anyone crossing them. Catra can't step on them without paying the price in pain, which seems like some kind of fucked up metaphor to her.

Her feet begin to ache, covered in dozens of tiny wounds from the rough surfaces of the planks, which she's beginning to think that some asshole designed to be intentionally uneven. Her hands start to blister from holding the ropes to steady herself. Every step becomes an ordeal, a battle against the bridge itself.

The rickety planks of the bridge begin to rattle ominously, and Catra swallows hard as she looks down and realizes that they're starting to become fewer and further between. She's never been afraid of heights before, but after the fall on Prime's ship, she's been scared of them in a bone-deep way that she buries beneath a veil of shame. She's not supposed to be *scared* of heights; she's supposed to always land on her feet, no matter how far she falls.

Looking down now, though, Catra can't see even a hint of the land; it's nothing but sky all the way down. She gets the uncomfortable feeling that if she fell, she'd be falling for the rest of her life.

Far in the distance, the golden light beckons her for a moment before disappearing behind a soft white cloud. Catra grits her teeth and continues onwards, spurred on by the reminder of what she's heading for.

As she stretches out precariously to reach the next plank, feeling the gaping yawn of the sky beneath her opening up like a giant mouth ready to pull her in, she feels a cold breeze blow across the

back of her neck: a breath, a caress. She looks over her shoulder in the direction it comes from - the north - and suddenly makes a desperate grab for the railings as she realizes what's heading towards her.

The gale hits her like a boulder, a blast of pure air pressing her to the jagged planks as the bridge tosses back and forth, a sapling in a hurricane. A thousand fingers of wind tear at her clothes, ripping at her skin with the keen edges of knives as a screeching howl fills the air around her, a hair-raising rush of high-pitched sound that comes from the wind itself and speaks of an anger that transcends word or meaning.

Catra's heart beats irregularly, stuttering in panic. She clings to the ropes as best she can, the bridge pitching like a ship on stormy seas. When she squints, trying to see through the opaque spiral of the gale, she catches a glimpse of something up ahead; it's only a brief glance, but she thinks it's the end of the bridge, the end of the wooden planks and flimsy ropes.

She gathers her courage and forces herself upright again, making a mad dash forward even as the wind bends her double and pulls her backwards. The ropes burn against her hands, cutting shallow trenches into the skin as she runs; the winds pick up speed, whirling around her so fast that the air is pulled from her lungs.

With her last breath, Catra stumbles one step further and falls to her knees, unable to continue. She's exhausted down to her very bones, in a way that she's only felt once before: on Prime's ship, hovering between life and death.

If you're going to kill me, she thinks, *then take me already. At least maybe then I'll see Adora again.*

The wind dies down, fading to a soft breeze that wraps around her once before departing. The surface beneath her wounded hands is cool and smooth.

--

Catra raises her head wearily to see that she's still on the bridge.

The wooden planks are gone, giving way to a wide stretch of grey stone that slides like the curve of a raindrop. When she starts walking again, the stone is cool and forgiving against her feet, soothing the angry wounds from the bridge before.

The air is heavier here; it weighs around her shoulders like a yoke, holding and gathering against her back. Catra walks like she's carrying a burden, slightly bent beneath its mass. She can't find any reasonable explanation for why the air should feel so heavy, and yet it lingers upon her like sadness in a cemetery: an intangible yet unbearable weight.

The bridge curves suddenly downwards, descending into a cloudbank; as Catra follows the slope, the clouds surround her until her vision is not a field but a snowstorm. She slows until she's barely moving, reaching out into the insubstantial wisps of cloud as if it will somehow help her navigate.

She's about halfway through the clouds - by her estimation, at least, a loose guess made more from hope than expectation - when she hears the voices.

A chorus of melancholy echoes through the clouds, wailing whispers rising and falling like a funeral dirge. As Catra walks, the cries start getting louder; they're eerily unsettling, not because they're inhuman, but because they're the exact opposite. Every voice that wails into the mist could be a parent who lost a child, a friend who lost their companion, a lover who lost their other half. The clouds fill with pure grief, spilling over like rainwater.

Catra finds herself mourning by osmosis: she becomes choked up, her throat tight with sadness. Tears spring unbidden to her eyes, but she manages to keep them from falling. She refuses to give anything else to this brutal and unforgiving land. It doesn't deserve her grief, and it doesn't deserve her tears.

As if in response, the air grows colder, pulling water from her eyes. Catra swipes them away roughly, continues walking.

Thoughts of Adora begin to run through Catra's mind, soft and peaceful moments slipping between one another: Adora covering them both with a blanket; Adora lying with her feet tucked under Catra's stomach; Adora sneaking an extra ration bar for Catra; Adora carefully bandaging a scratch on Catra's arm after training. The memories shift like reflections in water, and Catra tries to think of more; a spaceship, a rooftop -

Her mind becomes hazy, a staticked blur of color pressing against the insides of her eyelids. The record scratches, goes silent, and she can't remember. She can't remember.

Catra's tears fall, sinking through the air like dropped diamonds. The instant they hit the bridge, salt water splashed against stone, it changes.

--

The bridge shifts beneath Catra's feet, the texture different but the color still the same; instead of the smooth veneer of weatherbeaten stone, it's now a pitted surface rife with dirt and pebbles.

Catra takes a tentative step forward, finds that it's solid to the touch and decent enough to walk on. She moves slowly as the aftermath of the harsh winds and her crying jag take their toll on her tired lungs, and her breaths come shortly.

She tries to remind herself that she's fine, that she's been through much worse than this before, but it's getting harder and harder to convince herself of that fact. She's weathered worse storms, true - she's crossed the Crimson Waste virtually alone, she's been swallowed by a portal that nearly destroyed reality, she's been kidnapped by an intergalactic fascist and reprogrammed to become a killing machine - but the horrors of those incidents are beginning to pale in comparison, fading like paint colors in water.

She feels removed from their memories in a strangely distant way, as if rather than things that happened to her in the past, they were stories told about a girl who looked like her.

Catra shakes her head, trying to focus herself again. She pins her eyes to the path ahead of her, relying on vision to ground her.

Cracks spread across the surface of the bridge, splintering it into sharp-cornered sections. Most of these fissures are filled with sparse soil and scrubby grasses, but a few have small flowers blooming from them, raising their small leaves towards the pale light. Their petals are mostly soft pinks and blues, but one is a dark violet that reminds Catra of something - someone - she knows. Used to know.

Does she know someone with purple hair? Catra searches her mind carefully, and after half a minute of thought, the name appears on the tip of her tongue: *Entrapta.*

She'd gotten Catra here, hadn't she? *Had* she?

"Fuck," Catra mumbles, the realization sinking in: she's beginning to forget the world above. She'd known that she had lost memories of Adora; she hadn't known that she'd lose ones of her other friends as well.

There is always more to lose, Anubis had said.

Catra tries to remember Bright Moon, Bow, Glimmer, the rest of the princesses. The recollections come in bits and pieces, a puzzle scattered haphazard and piecemeal across the foreground of her mind. She remembers Glimmer's pink hair, but doesn't know what style it was the last time they saw each other. She remembers Bow's cropped shirts, but not the color of his eyes. She can't quite remember the sound of Perfuma's voice.

She thinks back further: the Fright Zone, the Horde. A dim series of images play back in her head, a poorly spliced film reel on a muted screen. She sees a room crowded with bunk beds, a row of green lockers, a short boy with blonde hair ducking as a brown-

haired girl throws something at him - *Lonnie,* Catra reminds herself, *and - and who?*

Adora appears amid the cascade of memories: smiling at her as they race, sitting next to her high atop somewhere - a rooftop, maybe? Catra presses her hands to her head, fingers tangling in her hair as she searches for something she can't reach.

"No," she says out loud. "Stop. I don't care what else you take, but you can't take her. I've already lost her once."

No one answers. The air is perfectly still around her.

If I get through this, Catra thinks wildly, *let me remember her. I'll do anything for it. I'll give you whatever you want.* She throws this message out into the metaphysical space that surrounds her, bargaining with a nameless power as desperation sweeps through the center of her soul.

As if in answer, the bridge changes once more beneath her.

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A warm glow of light fills Catra's eyes, shining upwards from the surface of the bridge. It's made of a pure white slowstone now; it's as smooth as the sea on a calm day, and shot through with brilliant streaks of gold that look like living things.

The bridge arches upwards and then downwards again, forming a perfect curve. The railings are solid and unwavering, made of the same white slowstone. Behind the bridge, Catra can see a half-open door from which golden light is shining out onto the end of the stonework. She's *here* .

She starts across the bridge, her aches and worries falling away as hope lends her wings. She's halfway to the other side when a figure appears at the far end of the bridge, blocking her way. Catra stops dead in her tracks.

The figure is a woman whose skin is made of pure gold, glimmering as brightly as the veins of precious metal that trace through the stone between them. Her eyes are solid black, no light in them at all; it's like making eye contact with midnight.

"Mortal," the woman says, and her voice is hollow, the ring of metal striking stone. "You may not pass."

Catra glares at her. "What do you mean, I can't pass?"

"You are alive," the woman replies. "The path beyond is only for those who have passed on."

"Yeah, whatever," Catra scoffs. She's come too far, endured too much to be checked by a walking metal sculpture. She takes another step forward, ready to fight her way through if necessary.

A wall of force hits her, locking her in place, the air suddenly a prison around her. She struggles until her limbs burn with the ache of effort, but she can barely move a muscle.

The woman walks up to her, placing one hand against her cheek. Catra feels the cool kiss of tempered metal sliding against her skin.

"You are weak," she says, her voice chiding, scornful. "You are not worthy of passage. But there is more than one way to cross a bridge, and despite your ineptitude, I suppose you want a second chance. Who wouldn't?"

She lifts Catra as easily as if she were a feather, then approaches the side of the bridge.

"You want to bring her back to the land of the living," she continues conversationally, "but the fact that you yourself are still living is the thing that will keep you from achieving that. Irony loves a cruel jest."

Catra thrashes in the woman's grip, her claws scoring uselessly against the shining alloy of her face. "Let go of me, you stupid statue!"

"I'll give you some advice," the woman says, her fingers wrapping around Catra's wrist hard enough to cause fractures. "Death is like time is like love. You can't fight it. All you can do is brace yourself for the fall."

She flings Catra over the side of the bridge, into the darkness of an endless abyss. Catra falls like a stone.

Air rushes by her, embracing her without breaking her descent. The fierce whistle of wind by her ears renders her half-deaf, and her eyes sting from the speed of it all, watering painlessly, drops of salt flying from her face in all directions. She tenses herself, curls into a taut spring of muscle coiled tight from fear and anticipation; if she ever lands, it will probably break half the bones in her body. She can practically hear the snap already.

Green light blots out the backs of her eyelids, filling her vision with a memory only partially formed; she's falling through different air in a different world, a hard metal floor waiting below. An unkept promise rings in her ears, and she's never heard it before, but it sounds strangely familiar -

A hand wraps around her wrist, the grip strong yet gentle. Catra's fall slows to a drag, catching on an updraft as the dark is pushed back by a pale lavender glow.

"Catra," someone says. A woman, pink-haired and pale-skinned, hovering next to her on a pair of gossamer wings that gleam like opal. Catra's old life may be fading from her mind, but she dimly registers the similarities between this woman and someone else she knows, someone important to her -

"Angella," Catra says, pronouncing the name carefully. A stab of guilt rushes through her, for reasons she can't identify. "Glimmer's mother?"

“Yes,” Angella replies. “Listen carefully. We don’t have much time.”

“You’re dead,” Catra says, the words tilting up at the end of the sentence, a question she can’t answer by herself. “That was my fault?”

“Yes,” Angella says again, but there’s no anger in her eyes. It’s an unearned absolution, and Catra’s stomach twists again in guilt.

“I can save you,” Catra says, even though she’s not sure she can. “If you come with me, if we find Adora together, maybe all of us can leave - ”

Angella shakes her head. “That is not my destiny,” she says. “I’ve passed on already. Don’t worry for me, Catra; I’m not unhappy. I’ve found a place in the world beyond where I can be happy, and a friend to keep me company. You’ve met her already.”

“Mara,” Catra murmurs.

“We belong here now,” Angella says. “But you don’t. You will find Adora soon, and you can bring her back, but you have to remember.”

Angella’s wings beat heavily around them, fighting the pull of gravity. Catra feels sleepy, her mind dulled by something she can’t yet understand. She forces out her next words with a great effort: “Remember what?”

“There’s no time,” Angella says. “I forgive you, Catra. And I trust you to do what must be done. Tell Glimmer - ” Lavender tears pool in the corner in the corner of her eyes, and Catra stares at them dazedly.

“Tell Glimmer and Micah and Bow I love them,” Angella finishes. “And take Adora home safely.”

She opens her hand and lets Catra fall, slipping from her grasp like a memory forgotten. The abyss reaches up towards Catra,

and this time there is no one left to catch her.

Adora, Catra thinks, and then she can think no more.

ASCEND

Chapter Notes

> the lovely rodstxr created an amazing piece for this fic, which you can find here
>
> and thank you to the mods of the 2021 she ra big bang for making this happen!
>
> disclaimer: it's about to get real harrow-the-ninth-coffee-shop-au in here. you've been warned. proceed

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Love is what we have, against time and death, against all the powers ranged to crush us down.

- Amal El-Mohtar, from *This Is How You Lose The Time War*

(THE FIFTH GATE)

A brightly lit room, a sky full of stars:

C'yra Driluth sits in the starboard conference room of the *Ekleipsis,* the roof arching high above her head. The conference table is a long oval of steel surrounded by ambassadors from all corners of the Empire, the holodeck in the center emitting a soft blue light as it projects a map of the solar system.

The ambassador from Asterion Hold is speaking now, a monologue about the state of the export industry in Zone Four. C'yra doesn't care about this; both the ambassador and their planet are far from her concern, so she lets her attention wander freely.

This is only her second time serving as Ambassador Nineteen, Halfmoon's representative at the intersolar conferences onboard the neutral ground satellite station - the *Ekleipsis* - that is the Capital of the Republic, and although she's prepared for all the veiled battles and cutthroat politics that are standard fare at these events, she's still not quite used to the splendor of the station itself.

The pen in her hands, provided at the door along with an elegant pad of legal-ruled manila scroll, is solid gold and encrusted with small white diamonds. The table at which they're sitting is pure platinum. To C'yra's right, beyond the crystalplex window, the starfield glimmers with the gold and silver lights of a thousand sparks, an entire celestial kingdom spread out in that sea of darkness.

It's all so *vast* . It fills C'yra with an indescribable kind of ache, a restless reaching for something more. Back on Halfmoon, her world dwindles to a singular point, a manageable sphere of existence; here on the *Ekleipsis,* no such limitation exists. It sits in the center of the solar system, the beating heart of an empire, bigger than all it contains.

It takes C'yra's breath away every time, but she has to take care to hide that fact. The other ambassadors are for the most part jaded and aged, concerned with nothing other than politics; if they knew she still felt like an awestruck child everytime she boarded the *Ekleipsis* , she'd be fucked within minutes - *which,* she reminds herself, *will happen anyway if I don't at least pretend to pay attention right now.*

Reluctantly, she focuses her mind once again on the discussion at hand.

“No,” the Asterion Hold ambassador is saying. C’yra racks her brain for his title - Ambassador Six, heir to the throne of Asterion Hold, but still a politician for all that. “We cannot allow you to place a tariff on inorganic exports through the Sector Six stargate. Do you take me for a fool? That is blatant highway robbery, and it will run our coffers dry. If you insist upon this further, Asterion Hold will have no choice but to take recriminatory action as we see fit.”

“Well,” the ambassador from Salineas drawls - Ambassador Three, Catra reminds herself - “if Asterion Hold is so poor that a twenty credit tariff is going to bankrupt it, then I’m kind of not worried about your so-called recriminatory action, you know?”

Ambassador Six turns red with rage, but the Salinean ambassador just waves her hand in reply. C’yra watches in mild interest, with a grudging admiration for Ambassador Three.

“This debate seems to need a moderator,” says the Plumerian representative - Ambassador Nine, who is so soft spoken that C’yra wonders how she ever got to be sitting in this room. “If I may allow - ”

“You may *not* ,” Ambassador Six insists, his expression outraged. He’s clearly never mastered the mask of indifference that C’yra has employed since the beginning of her career as a diplomat. “Asterion Hold is *bleeding* . Don’t sit there and tell me that you can’t see my side of the issue! We have *people* to feed, we have *an economy* to revitalize, we have - ”

The hiss of the pneumatic hyperdoors drowns out the rest of his sentence, leaving C’yra to wonder what word he would have emphasized next. The servant standing by the doors raises their arms in standard Capital courtesy, then announces: “Presenting the delegation from Eternia, Ambassador Thirteen.”

Ambassador Thirteen steps into the room, taking the empty seat next to Ambassador Ten that sits diagonally opposite from C’yra.

“Apologies for the delay in my arrival,” Ambassador Thirteen says. “We had to stop by Zone Four to help the colony of Salix with an invasion of stareaters.” She picks a bit of something unidentifiable from the edge of her shirt, flicking it away with a look of embarrassment. “Uh. As you were. Carry on.”

“As I was *saying* ,” Ambassador Six says, no doubt continuing his lengthy diatribe, but C’yra is no longer listening.

Ambassador Thirteen turns to the light, and C’yra’s world explodes like a dying star.

Ambassador Thirteen is, without question, the prettiest person C’yra has ever seen. Her hair falls in gentle waves, shining with a luminescent gold that the twin moons of Halfmoon would beg to rival. Her eyes are the stormy grey of a starshine nebula; when she blinks, it’s as if the entire galaxy blinks along with her. She’s the brightest thing in the room.

C’yra realizes, dimly, that she’s staring. She doesn't stop, *can’t* stop. Every molecule of her being feels like it’s reaching for Ambassador Thirteen, gravity pulling planets into orbit, driven by a force she can’t yet name. She’s never seen the woman before in her life, but something in her recognizes something in Ambassador Thirteen on a fundamental level. Watching her is like crossing the threshold of one’s childhood home, C’yra thinks: familiar and yet distant, all at once.

She forgets about debates, about politics, about her diplomatic mission. She forgets about everything other than Ambassador Thirteen. Sight becomes a tunnel, sound an ocean surrounding her; she’s unaware of anything in the room besides the set of Ambassador Thirteen’s mouth and the spark in her eyes and the gold of her hair.

“I would like to address the request put in two moons ago,” Ambassador Thirteen says, and the sound of her voice is a clarion call, a tuning fork struck and held to the center of C’yra’s chest.

“Eternia previously requested, on the condition of a temporary grant, control over Etheria Station in Zone Nine.”

C’yra is so entranced by the sound of her voice that she barely hears the actual words, but slowly their meanings start to register, and then -

“Hell *no,”* C’yra mutters to herself.

“Well,” says Ambassador Two, the representative of Bright Moon. “That request has been pending for an intermediary period, but I believe that it may be granted upon your terms; however, if Eternia uses it for military acts rather than resource harvesting, then the consequences will be dire.”

“Understood and agreed,” Ambassador Thirteen says, the corner of her mouth pulling up in a satisfied smirk that drives C’yra mad to look at. “I’ll pass that on to the court when I return.”

“It’s settled, then,” Ambassador Two says, and C’yra can’t contain herself anymore.

“Nothing’s *settled* ,” she says, her tone carefully controlled. “Halfmoon also laid claim to Etheria Station - *three* months ago, I might remind you - and you’re telling me that you’re willing to hand it over to Eternia without a second thought?

Ambassador Thirteen turns to look at her, and their eyes meet like stars colliding. C’yra is blown away beneath the sheer brilliance of blue-edged grey, an interstellar shift occurring in the space between them, but she refuses to let it derail her.

“I challenge your claim to Etheria Station,” she continues. “And I assure you that Halfmoon is more than capable - and willing - to fight for the station with more than just contradictory words, if necessary.”

“Etheria Station is closer to Eternia, you know,” Ambassador Thirteen says, her eyes sparking now.

“Immaterial,” C’yra counters. “The distance is negligible. It’s what, two kliks northwest by nineteen degrees? Hardly an extra ten minutes of sub-light travel.”

“Still, it’s closer to us,” Ambassador Thirteen insists. “As well, before we make any momentous decisions on this matter, I would like to remind the other ambassadors of the events that occurred last solstice. Surely it would be better for Eternia to have use of Etheria Station, in case of future incidents of that nature?”

C’yra grits her teeth. Ambassador Thirteen is indirectly reminding the Council that half or more of them owe her their lives in the aftermath of the alien threat ten moons ago. Leverage has always been a tricky thing, but Ambassador Thirteen has her hand on the fulcrum of this room. Murmuring breaks out between the other ambassadors.

Commander Astrid raises a hand, and the room falls silent. As the military leader of the *Ekleipsis,* she usually doesn’t get involved with interkingdom politics unless they affect the entire solar system, but when she does, her word carries more weight than anyone else in the Republic.

“Both ambassadors have laid a material claim to the station,” she says, her voice pure authority sung in alto stanzas. “I recommend that we break for today and reconvene tomorrow, where we will review the validity of each claim.”

The other ambassadors nod and gather their things, starting to leave. C’yra remains where she is, one eye on the door and the other on Ambassador Thirteen, who’s still at the table.

“You,” C’yra says furiously, the second that they’re alone in the room.

Ambassador Thirteen looks up at her, surprised. “Ambassador Nineteen.”

“Don’t give me the slick political crap,” C’yra says, and she’s jeopardizing her diplomatic reputation here, but she doesn't care -

she's too mad at Ambassador Thirteen; mad that she's trying to swipe Etheria Station from under Halfmoon's nose, mad that she's infuriatingly smug about it, mad that she's *so* damn attractive. "Claiming the station? You *know* that we put in a claim before you did."

"I didn't, actually," Ambassador Thirteen says. "I haven't been here for the last few conferences; I had missions on the outer reaches. Hey, are you new? I don't remember seeing you before."

"No, I'm not!" C'yra splutters. "For your information, this is my second time here, and I know exactly what's going on, so don't think you can go screwing me over just because I'm from Halfmoon and not one of your precious diplomat princesses."

Ambassador Thirteen smirks again, and C'yra wants to punch her, wants to kiss it right off her mouth -

"I'll keep that in mind," Ambassador Thirteen says.

C'yra narrows her eyes. "You may be dangerous, but if you keep pushing Halfmoon, you'll find that I am too."

Ambassador Thirteen stands up now, and she's so tall it's a matter of impracticality - C'yra is forced to tilt her head back to look at her properly.

"You think I'm dangerous," Ambassador Thirteen says softly, her face barely inches from C'yra's. The air grows heavy between them. C'ra feels her heartbeat speed up, flickering hotly in her chest, a double-time, quicksilver rhythm. "Do you want to find out just how right you are?"

"How?" C'yra asks, fighting to keep her tone neutral even as her body betrays her: she's leaning forward, bending to Ambassador Thirteen like a flower to the sun.

"Get dinner with me," Ambassador Thirteen says, and then: "Um. If you want to, that is." She grins sheepishly. It's such a change from the ruthless politician facade of seconds earlier that it sends

C’yra’s head spinning, and oh - she’d wanted to disarm her, but *this* -

“Okay,” C’yra says, and it’s a terrible idea. Red lights flash at the edges of her vision, but she blinks right through them; Ambassador Thirteen smiles at her crookedly, and it’s more than worth it.

“Nine at the Artemis?” she asks. “I’ll pick you up. See you then.”

“Wait,” C’yra says. “I don’t even know your name.”

Ambassador Thirteen arches an eyebrow. “What’s *your* name?”

“C’yra.” She’s losing their game, but she doesn’t care anymore.

“C’yra,” Ambassador Thirteen repeats thoughtfully, rolling the name around like it doesn’t quite fit right in her mouth. “Nice to meet you. I’m Adora.”

She shoots C’yra one last grin and then slips out the door, leaving C’yra standing there dazedly. *Adora,* she thinks, and can’t help smiling to herself.

She allows herself one more moment of stupid happiness, and then she heads to her room. She’s got a date to dress for.

--

At eight forty-five, C’yra finds herself sitting in the sun temple on the upper level of the *Ekleipsis.* Unlike the Capital, Halfmoon follows the crescent moon, and C’yra barely practices religion anyway, but something drew her here tonight for reasons she can’t explain.

The altar looms above her, filigree gold hammered into the spear-sharp shape of the sun. The only light in the room comes from the permanently lit candles ringing the steps of the rostrum and the circular starpane above her head, which allows a thin beam of starlight to fall directly onto the altar.

C’yra kneels on the sandstone-tiled floor and stares up at the altar, absorbing the glittering rays of gold. She’s never really understood the Capital’s obsession with the sun before, but now she does.

The altar curves like the corner of Adora’s smile, and C’yra can’t think about anything else; it’s an offer of dinner, a first night that could also be the last, but there’s something here that runs deeper. She knows she’s acting irrational, but she can’t help it: something about Adora brings her to her knees, instilling a devotion deeper than one meeting in one lifetime. It’s as if they’ve met before, as if today was only a single chapter in a story as old as love itself.

“Hey,” says a voice from behind her. “Told you I’d find you.”

C’yra turns to see Adora there, leaning against the frame of the door, wearing a simple black blazer with a gold dress shirt and a white tie hanging loose around her neck. Her hair is pulled up and tied back, but a few strands are falling free on one side.

“Well look who decided to show up,” C’yra replies, getting to her feet. She quickly straightens the collar of her own shirt; she’d opted for a black tuxedo over a silver shirt, no tie. She thinks Adora will like it. She *hopes* Adora will like it.

Adora eyes her appreciatively. “We’re standing in a temple,” she says, “and you’re still the only thing in the room worth worshipping.”

“I bet you say that to all the diplomats,” C’yra scoffs, pretending that her heart isn’t fluttering like a bird trapped between her ribs.

“Only the pretty ones,” Adora says, her smile crooked. Then, softer: “No. Only you.”

C’yra grins despite herself. “Awfully forward for the first date, don’t you think?”

“Not if I’m sure there’s going to be more,” Adora answers. She turns towards the altar, one hand pressed to her chest, and bows

slightly in a formal gesture of respect. That done, she holds one hand out to C'yra. "Shall we?"

"I guess so," C'yra says, trying for a tone of indifference and missing by a starfield mile. "But this is not because I like you."

Adora just laughs. C'yra takes her hand.

"You know," Adora says as they leave the temple, "I'm kind of surprised that you were here. I thought that Halfmoon followed the moon, but I guess I was wrong. Do you follow the sun, then?"

C'yra glances over at her: the soft curves of her profile, the sharp line of her jaw, the starfire intensity of her eyes. She thinks of the strange familiarity that she feels between them, a soft but unyielding magnetic pull of a force, her compass point drawn to Adora's north star.

"Yeah," she says. "Sometimes it feels like I've followed it my whole life."

--

The Artemis is the most upscale restaurant on the *Ekleipsis,* but Adora gets them a table next to the window like it's nothing at all. C'yra leans back in her chair, taps a knife against the diamond champagne flute sitting at her place; Adora braces her forearms on the edge of the table, smiling at her. Outside, the vast reaches of the starfield send soft light slanting through the crystalglass.

"So," C'yra says finally, setting down her knife. "What do you do when you're not trying to steal other kingdoms' territory?"

"I'm not trying to *steal* -"

"Yeah, alright," C'yra sighs. "No politics tonight, then. Answer the rest of the question."

Adora raises one shoulder in a shrug. “I like traveling a lot, but just for fun, not for diplomatic missions. I like combat training. I do a lot of that with Adam - he’s my twin brother.” The line of her mouth creases downwards, a well-worn tic, and C’yra catalogues the movement.

“Let me guess,” she says. “He was born first.”

“How did you know?”

C’yra laughs. Adora scowls.

“Whatever, like six minutes even make a difference,” she mumbles. “Anyways - I like flying. Spacecraft, but planet skimmers too. I do mechanical work for the Etherian fleet when I have time, although if you ask my mother, that’s not a *proper* interest for a princess to have. What about you?”

“I have a lot of hobbies,” C’yra says, smirking at her. “They include being hot, kicking people’s asses, and making fun of uptight diplomats.”

Adora’s eyes flicker with amusement, and something else - something darker. She leans across the table.

“I am *not* uptight,” she says. “But I won’t argue with you on the first point.”

C’yra blushes, and is acutely aware of it: the rush of heat beneath her skin, the hot twist of anticipation low in her stomach. Adora settles back in her chair, her smile lopsided and self-satisfied.

A waiter comes by, discreetly placing a pair of menus on the table. C’yra picks one up, scans it: confits, lemongrasses, tartares, petals in sauce, all for exorbitant prices.

“What’s your favorite food?” she asks curiously.

Adora looks up from her menu. “Here?”

C’yra shakes her head. “From home.”

A wistful expression spreads over Adora’s face, and for just a moment, C’yra aches to reach for her, not for anything sexual or romantic, but for the simple act of physical connection.

“Well,” Adora says. “There’s this old lady named Razz who lives outside our palace, and she makes the best pies you’ve ever tasted. She calls me by the wrong name half the time, but I try to visit her every month to help her pick berries for the filling. And - yeah, her pies are probably my favorite food.”

“Oh,” C’yra says, and feels herself smiling. “That’s sweet. You’re a good person when you’re not being a soulless cutthroat politician.”

Adora sighs. “You’re not going to let go of that, are you?” She closes her menu. “Seriously, if you - if Halfmoon needs the station that bad, I’ll let you have it.”

C’yra pauses. “What?”

“It’ll probably get me murdered when I go home, but…” The corner of Adora’s mouth quirks. “Well. For you…”

C’yra stares at her, searching for insincerity and finding none; there’s nothing but affection in Adora’s eyes. It’s so much, so soon. It sweeps C’yra off her feet.

“I like stargazing,” she says, in lieu of a proper answer. “That’s what I did for my entire childhood. What I do still. For years and years, my favorite thing to do was sit on the rooftop and watch the stars, telling myself that someday I’d sail among them. And now - ” She gestures out the window. “Now I do.”

Adora watches her: chin resting on her hand, lips slightly parted. C’yra’s gaze catches on the curve of her bottom lip.

“We’ve never met before, right?” Adora says finally. “Like, you’re sure of that?”

“I’m sure,” C’yra says. She lets her voice fall lower. “I guess we’ll have to make up for lost time.”

Adora closes her menu, places it deliberately back on the table. “Is there anything here you actually want?”

“Yes,” C’yra answers, keeping her eyes locked on Adora’s mouth, “but not from the restaurant.”

Adora’s smile returns, the crooked curl sharper now, but somehow still gentle. C’yra knows somehow, instinctively, that Adora is a blade in the right hands, but here in front of her, she’s a blossom without thorns.

“Wanna get out of here?” Adora asks.

She holds out her hand. Once again, C’yra takes it.

--

They find their way back to Adora’s room somehow, drunk off lingering touches and wandering hands. Adora pulls them over the threshold, shuts the door behind them; her jacket drops to the floor, closely followed by Adora’s.

“Hey,” C’yra says, glancing towards the window as she slides one hand beneath Adora’s shirt, pressing an open-mouthed kiss to Adora’s neck and scraping her teeth along the skin. “That’s not fair - they gave you a better room than me. I only have a starpane, not a real window.”

Adora’s breaths are coming fast, her eyes dark with desire. “Is that *really* what you want to talk about right now?” she asks, and C’yra has to admit that she has a point.

Adora pulls C’yra’s shirt over her head and then takes off her own, and C’yra takes a moment to appreciate the view; Adora is all hard edges and curves, her skin pale gold in the wash of starlight. C’yra runs her hand over Adora’s hip, pulling her closer, and brings

their mouths together in a kiss that's so easy, so instinctive, it feels like they've been doing this for years.

"Bed," Adora manages to say, breaking away long enough to inhale sharply. "Now."

C'yra flashes her a smile, all teeth in the dim light. "You're not in charge here, princess."

Adora's reply is lost in another kiss. They fall back onto the bed, shedding their remaining clothes until there's nothing left between them but skin; C'yra flips them over, pushing Adora back into the mattress as the evening covers them like a blanket.

"This is okay, right?" Adora asks softly, even though she's not in control, and C'yra's heart aches. There's something so raw, so infinitely tender about the affirmation.

"Of course it is, dumbass," she answers fondly. "Enough talking." She presses her lips to Adora's again, slides her hand along the inside of Adora's thigh and lets her fingers drift higher. The universe collapses around them, fitting itself into the corners of the room until they're the only two people within it.

Outside, the stars shine more brightly than C'yra's ever seen them before.

--

C'yra wakes slowly, pulled back to consciousness by the absence of warmth. Her fingers reach to the other side of the bed for Adora, but find only creased sheets. She opens her eyes, disoriented.

It's still nighttime, the sky too pale for anything other than starlight to be illuminating it. Adora is standing at the window, staring out into the night. C'yra notices that she's wearing a shirt now.

"Adora?"

“Oh, hey,” Adora says, turning. “Sorry. I couldn’t sleep, and I didn’t want to bother you by staying in bed because I couldn’t lie still anymore.”

C’yra slips out of bed, pulling her own shirt back on, and pads across the room to join her. They sit in companionable silence, shoulders pressed together, and it’s not awkward even though it should be. In front of them, the starfield shines with the brilliance of eternity. Adora glances at her, smiling softly.

“Was this what it felt like when you were a kid?” Adora asks finally.

C’yra looks out at the stars, charting their spill across the sky, the infinite possibility that paints itself in pinpricks of bright light against the darkness. She thinks of her childhood, staring up at the constellations and wondering what it would like to hold them. Adora’s fingers brush against hers, interlacing at the tips, and in this moment, C’yra swears she could gather the planets in her cupped hands.

“Yeah,” she says. “This is what it felt like.”

Adora leans into her, head against the space between her neck and shoulder. “Tell me something else about your childhood.”

C’yra thinks back to her earliest days in Halfmoon, trying to find a story that will make Adora laugh, but then she frowns in confusion. There’s nothing there, no distinct memories; everything is hazy and muted, shadowed beneath something she can’t shift away.

“That’s weird,” she says slowly. “I don’t remember.”

Adora’s voice is harsher now, almost angry. “You don’t?”

C’yra blinks, presses a hand to her head; a spike of pain shoots from her temples, curling in her brain. She should remember, she *should* -

There's a brittle sound of breaking, and C'yra watches in horror as a spider web of cracks appears on the surface of the window. She scrambles back, pushing Adora behind her.

"We have to get out," she says desperately, and now the cracks are growing wider, the window shattering into a million shards of crystalplex as the stars grow brighter and brighter, all the air sucked out of the room like a relentless inhale -

The light reaches into the room, shining until C'yra is forced to look away from the blinding force of it; it surrounds Adora, pulling her backwards through the fragmented remains of the window, flinging her out into space. She falls backwards slowly, her hand reaching out hopelessly towards C'yra.

Adora, C'yra wants to scream, but there's no more breath in her lungs. She stretches out until her arm burns with the pain of it, her fingers slipping short of Adora's. Blackness encroaches on the edges of her vision, dancing in the corners of her eyes.

With her last moment of awareness, C'yra pushes through the open window and out into the void. All around her, the stars rush forward to catch her.

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(THE SIXTH GATE)

A softly lit hall, a palace full of music:

Catra stands at the door of a ballroom, wondering how exactly she got here.

She’s wearing a flowing white shirt with large sleeves, edged with gold thread, and a pair of leather pants; her boots are made from sturdy black leather. There’s a cape draped around her, crimson with golden trim, and a sword is slung across her back, the hilt rising above her right shoulder.

The ballroom looks vaguely familiar: it’s a long dance hall filled with crystal chandeliers and candles flickering yellow, the walls made from elaborately carved marble. A tapestry hangs on the far wall, the fabric a rich cerulean blue against an elaborate pattern of black and gold. Some kind of crest, Catra thinks; it looks familiar, but she can’t quite place it.

The music is slow and peaceful, a many-string serenade of a melody that drifts around the room like it has wings. Behind the musicians, beyond the raised platform on which they sit with their instruments, a row of floor-to-ceiling windows are thrown open to let in a warm summer breeze. People fill the hall, all dressed in elegant evening wear: some are dancing to the orchestra, some are talking quietly at the refreshments table. None of them have spotted her yet.

Catra looks around slowly, trying to place herself somewhere in this tableau. She knows that belongs here for some reason, but she can’t quite remember why. She thinks back to the past few weeks, months, years, but finds nothing more than two days of lying in a bed, surrounded by people whose faces slip from her remembrance - two days and nothing more, nothing past that.

She reaches over her shoulder for her sword, wrapping her fingers around the wire-twisted handgrip. That much, she can deal with; the hilt is solid and familiar, fitting into her grasp like the hand of a lover. She holds it tighter, until the wires begin to dig into her palm, and tries not to panic over the evasive nature of her memory.

“Knight Catra,” someone says.

Catra turns. There's a boy standing next to her in a gold-trimmed palace uniform that looks slightly too big for him; his cap is falling over his eyes, and his tunic is almost as long as his body. He's only half her height, and he's looking up at her with respect - no, reverence - in his eyes.

"Yes?" Catra says, confused.

"Come with me, please," the boy says. "The princess instructed me to bring you to the royal table as soon as you arrived."

Catra follows him through the crowd until they reach a table that Catra hadn't noticed before, tucked in the back of the hall in front of a tall pair of stained glass windows. Sitting at the table are a few councilor-looking types dressed in green and gold robes, and among them, sitting on a simple throne of silver, is a girl with golden hair.

"Princess Adora," says the boy, grabbing Catra's sleeve and pushing her slightly forward. "I brought you Knight Catra, like you said."

The girl looks up, meeting Catra's eyes: startling grey, the color of storm clouds before rain. Catra stares back. There's so much sadness in the girl's eyes that a sudden ache spreads through Catra's chest as she looks at her. She wonders, briefly and uselessly, if she's the cause of this sadness.

Adora, she thinks to herself. *Princess Adora.* The name, the title; they hold an indeterminate weight for her, as if spoken in a language she once knew. Catra shakes her head, trying to focus: she sees a quick flash of something playing across her vision, green and black and red - a battlefield, a glowing golden light snuffed out by darkness -

She blinks, and it's gone.

"Thank you," Princess Adora says, nodding to the boy, who squeaks out something like a *Your Highness* and runs away. She fixes her gaze on Catra again, as if studying an unmapped terrain.

“Knight,” she says, and there’s something else flickering in her eyes now: a raw, broken hope that slips between despair and sorrow. “You remembered the ball.”

“Yes,” Catra says, and then frowns. She *did* remember, didn’t she? She’s here, after all. “I think so. I mean, here I am.”

“I wasn’t sure you’d make it,” Princess Adora murmurs, more to herself than to Catra. “You only came back....you only woke up a couple of days ago.”

Catra stretches a little, relieving the tension in her shoulders, and now she feels it: her muscles ache as if they haven’t been used in a long time, a phantom soreness lingering in the crooks of her body like she’s been lying alone on hard ground. Princess Adora is watching her carefully, and so sadly, and Catra thinks her heart might break if she has to see this for one more second. Her body hurts, but Adora’s pain hurts her more.

“I’m fine,” Catra says hastily. “Really, Princess Adora. I promise you. I’m fine.”

Princess Adora winces like Catra’s struck her. “Please,” she says - quietly enough that it blends with the hum of the music, quietly enough that no one else can hear. “Not *Princess* . Just Adora.”

It feels like they’ve had this conversation before. Catra swallows hard.

“Adora,” she says softly, the familiarity warm and bittersweet, stinging like blood in her mouth. “What happened to me? Why can’t I remember...anything?”

Adora rises from her throne, and Catra notices that her dress is made of white silk with gold accents. Something about the combination of colors catches at her attention, a vague recollection scratching at the back of her skull.

“Come with me,” Adora says. “We should talk about this somewhere else.”

--

Adora leads her out onto the terrace outside the ballroom, where a garden flourishes at the edge of the smooth terracotta tiles. Catra sits with her back beneath a cherry tree, running her hands through the small pink blossoms. Adora sits next to her, within reach but not close enough to touch.

For a minute, they're quiet. The strains of the orchestra are fainter out here, and the air feels warm and dry against her skin. Adora is beautiful in the dim light of the garden, and this moment would be perfect, except it's all wrong because Catra *can't remember.*

"What happened to me?" she asks, when it seems like the silence will stretch on until the sunrise.

Adora picks up a cherry blossom, twisting the petals between her fingers and letting them drop one by one. A memory surfaces vaguely in Catra's mind as she watches, a blurry recollection: a fistful of flowers, Adora's arm around her shoulder, petals falling from their hands - *she loves me, she loves me not* -

"We were fighting someone," Adora answers. Her voice wavers, but her eyes don't stray from Catra's. "Prime. The embodiment of evil. He was trying to bring ten thousand years of darkness to Etheria, and we had to stop him. We defeated him - well, we pushed him back, at least. But there was a price."

Catra tries to take all of this in. The name *Prime* is vaguely familiar, evoking something in her: the same flashes from earlier, green light and darkness and the crimson spill of blood. A fear of teeth, a childish nightmare, a sleep plagued by visions of a death that was never quite permanent.

"What did it cost?" she asks.

"Too much," Adora says, and then: "Everything."

The last petal drops from her flower, and a breeze sweeps forward to carry it off into the night. Catra watches as it drifts higher and

higher and then finally vanishes from sight. From where she's sitting, it looks like it melts into the stars themselves.

"You were asleep for a hundred years," Adora says shakily. "I - I thought you were *dead* . I didn't think you'd ever come back."

Catra doesn't know how to answer that. She doesn't even know if she *has* come back. It feels like there's still a piece of her missing, something that only recollection can replace: a rough-edged vacancy in the center of her mind, the loss of her memory like the destruction of a kingdom in all of its calamitous ruin.

There are still a million questions running through her head, but she doesn't ask them. She reaches for Adora instead, because it seems to be the easiest thing, the truest thing she can think to do - she reaches for her without fear, their hands joining between them like a bridge.

"I'm here now," she says.

Adora moves closer to her, tentatively at first, like she's not sure it's allowed. Catra pulls her closer, and the dam breaks all at once; Adora climbs into her lap, wraps her into a hug until they're intertwined so closely that Catra can't tell where she ends and Adora begins.

"I'm sorry," she whispers into Adora's hair. "I'm sorry for everything."

Adora laughs brokenly, her lips pressed against Catra's neck. "You used to say you'd never apologize to anyone - do you remember that? You said you didn't want the world to see you like that."

"I'll let *you* see me like that," Catra answers, and tries not to think about the fact that she no longer sees any difference between those two things.

Inside the ballroom, the music changes: it shifts from an allemande to a waltz, the irregular rhythm slow and steady, like a

heart caught between beats. Adora tips her head back, listening. “Waltz #2,” she says. “It’s the last dance of the night.”

There’s a petal caught in her hair, blushing pink against the waves of gold. Catra leans forward to gently pick it out.

“Do you want to go back in?” Catra asks. “If it’s the last dance, you should probably be there.”

Adora smiles for the first time - it’s a barely-there quirk at the corner of her mouth, like a glimpse of the sun between the clouds. Even through the unshed tears in her eyes, it carries a smoldering ember of warmth, a spark of happiness.

“I guess I might as well, now that you’re here,” she answers. “I was saving it for you.”

--

The floor of the ballroom is filled with dancing couples, but they part for Adora and Catra like waves beneath the prow of a ship. Adora leads Catra into the center of the room, below a chandelier filled with candles. Catra glances up at the crystal lattice dubiously, watching the way that the structure sways back and forth in the breeze.

“You’re sure this is safe, right? Like, that thing isn’t going to collapse on us and set us on fire?”

Adora laughs, and the sound rings bright in Catra’s chest. She’d endure a thousand chandeliers falling on her head if it meant she’d hear that laugh again.

“God, I forgot how dumb you are sometimes,” Adora says, her voice soft with affection. “No, it won’t fall on us. Come here.”

She takes Catra’s left hand in hers, putting her free hand on Catra’s shoulder; Catra places her right hand at the small of Adora’s back, her fingers finding the slight curved hollow at the base of her spine and pressing into it like they’ve done this a

hundred times before. They move to the music, small steps that keep them close together: Adora leading, Catra following.

Catra finds herself struggling to keep herself waltzing with the rhythm, her knees curiously weak as she moves; she missteps and trips, falling forward, but Adora catches her easily with an arm around her waist.

“Easy there,” Adora says, her voice light but carrying concern beneath the levity. “It’ll probably take a little while longer for you to fully regain your strength. You’re kind of weak right now.”

Catra jokingly gives her an indignant look. “Rude.”

“No,” Adora protests, but she’s smiling again, and the sight of it burns in Catra’s chest. “I mean, you were lying on a stone slab for a hundred years. That would make anyone’s body a bit weak.”

“Yeah,” Catra says, her heart dropping again at the reminder. She can’t remember a single one of those hundred years. Can’t remember anything from before them, either. Adora looks down at her, worry written into the lines of her face, and Catra wants to place her thumb at the corner of her mouth and smooth it away - god, how could she have been gone that long? How could she have survived that long without Adora?

She doesn’t know, and she doesn’t think she wants to. The thought of a hundred-year night without Adora to light the darkness makes her feel like her lungs are filling with seawater, every breath a lesson in drowning.

“I have more questions,” she says. “About when I was gone. About everything.”

Adora nods. “I know.”

“But not yet,” Catra says. She leans into Adora, presses her head to Adora’s chest. Adora’s heart beats steadily, in perfect time with Catra’s own. “For now, we can just dance.”

They fall silent, touch replacing speech, nothing left between them but music. The strings of the orchestra fade out slowly, quarter notes drifting away into the night, until the waltz is finished and the other couples have left.

They're the only two dancers still out on the floor. Catra holds Adora tightly, not wanting to let go even though the song is over.

"That was the last dance," Adora says softly. "It's over now."

"I know," Catra replies, just as soft - a sunlight ray, a flower petal of an answer.

The music is gone, and the night envelops them in quiet, and still neither of them pull away. Catra wraps her arms around Adora.

I won't let go, she thinks. *Not even if you do.*

Adora doesn't. They stay where they are, conversing in ways that words could never hope to replicate: Adora's fingers cradling the back of Catra's head, Catra's arms wound tight around Adora's waist. It's enough, Catra thinks. It's enough just to touch Adora, to know that she's alive and to reassure her of the same.

"You should get some sleep," Adora says finally, her mouth pressed to the top of Catra's forehead in a way that could almost be mistaken for a kiss.

Catra shakes her head. "Don't need it." She's been sleeping for a hundred years - the only thing she needs now is to stay by Adora's side until they've made up for lost time, until time means nothing to them.

"Catra," Adora says, her tone gentle but firm. "You're not fully recovered. You need to sleep."

Catra opens her mouth to argue, but a yawn overtakes her words. Adora looks at her pointedly.

“Fine,” Catra agrees reluctantly. “I’ll sleep. But I’ll walk you back to your room first.”

--

They walk through the corridors quietly, not wanting to disturb anyone who’s already gone to sleep. The bright lights of the palace have burned themselves out by now, and the hallways are lit only by the muted glow of candles in the wall sconces, the shadows of their flames dancing against the stone.

Catra feels better as they walk: there’s a slight lessening of the ache at her temples, the pain of forgetting. She still draws a blank when she reaches for memories of the past, but the palace itself is no mystery; it slowly opens itself to her, hallways and doorways revealing their thresholds, the layout a clouded mirror slowly wiped clean. She remembers this: the warm yellow stone of the walls, the red and golden threads of the carpets, the twists and turns of staircase and corridor. She remembers the path to the armory, the courtyard, the throne room, the kitchen.

She remembers the pathway to *here,* the tall oak door that Adora stops in front of. She remembers the white roses that grow across the lintel, the intricate rose that’s carved into the surface of the polished wood.

Adora’s looking at her now with a question in her eyes. Catra nods in response.

“This is your room,” she says. “I remember that.”

“Is that all you remember?” Adora says, and there’s a flash of something in her eyes, gone too quickly for Catra to identify. It might have been disappointment, or it might have been sadness.

“Yeah,” Catra says, uncertain. “Is there something else I’m supposed to remember about it?”

Adora shakes her head quickly. “No,” she murmurs. “It’s fine.” She steps forward, as if to hug Catra, and then steps backward just as

quickly. Boundaries, then; they're finding them again, drawing lines they'll end up crossing anyways. They've fallen into this pattern before, Catra thinks.

"Goodnight, Catra," Adora says, opening the door to her room but not quite entering.

Catra wants to reach for her - wants to follow her into the room, wants to fall asleep in her arms. This urge supersedes desire; it feels more like a visceral need, like one of her deepest instincts, but she knows just as instinctively that it's not allowed.

"Goodnight, Adora," she says instead. Before she can stay another minute, she turns and walks away.

--

Catra lies in her own bed later that night, shifting uncomfortably between the sheets. They're smoother than silk and smell faintly of lavender. Although she knows nothing about fabric, she can tell that this is one of the fanciest beds in the entire palace.

She hates it.

The mattress is too soft, yielding beneath her like grass in a meadow. The scent of lavender fills her senses, threatening to choke her. It doesn't smell subtle, or natural, or -

It doesn't smell like Adora.

Catra rolls over onto her side, her ribs aching with the movement. The bed feels too large, and the sheets feel too soft, and everything is too much. She feels unmoored, set adrift in a strange sea. She longs for an anchor.

After another five minutes of tossing and turning, she gets up from her bed and makes her way into the corridor, following the familiar path without conscious thought. If she remembers anything from her past, it's that Adora is her gravity: keeping her

grounded, keeping her alive. Catra knows it's probably selfish to wake her this late, but she doesn't know what else to do.

She reaches Adora's door and knocks three times, softly; it flies open almost immediately and Adora appears in the doorway, wearing a simple white shirt that falls to her knees.

"Catra," she says. "What's wrong? Are you okay?"

"I'm fine," Catra rushes to say. "I just - I can't sleep. I know that sounds stupid, but..."

Adora's expression softens. She doesn't say anything; instead, she just steps back to allow Catra into the room.

Inside, illuminated by the soft light of a single candle, Adora's room is a study in white and gold. The bed is wide enough for four people, the sheets a pristine white and the duvet a pale golden fabric that looks like it's woven out of strands of the precious metal. The windows are slightly ajar, letting in the breeze. The walls are bare except for one painting above the mahogany desk: a starscape, sun and moon framed against a backdrop of constellations, the colors a wild surrealist swirl of blue and gold.

At the foot of Adora's bed, there's a large cot that lies perpendicular to it, made up with sturdy cotton sheets. Catra looks at it longingly; she's sure that it would be more comfortable than her own bed.

"You can sleep there," Adora says, following her gaze. "That - that's where you used to sleep. Before. It used to…" She pauses, and Catra can see a faint blush painting across her cheeks. "It used to be *our* room."

First person plural. Possessive. Catra's heart leaps in her chest, climbing into her throat. She gets into the cot, propping herself up on one elbow to watch Adora slide into her own bed, and it's perfect; the mattress is firm beneath her, and Adora is within a

breath's length from her, and Catra no longer feels like the world is collapsing around her.

Adora blows out the candle, and they're left in the dark.

"Thank you," Catra says, barely above a whisper.

"Of course," Adora answers, her voice like a banked fire against the darkness: warm, gentle, comforting. "I'm always going to be here for you."

Catra's throat thickens with emotion, because she can't say the same; she *left* Adora for a hundred years, left her alone and defenseless. She wants to apologize again, but she doesn't think she'll ever find enough words.

"Goodnight," Adora says now, her voice soft and tired, and Catra murmurs a "goodnight" in response. She falls asleep to the sound of Adora's breathing, quiet and steady like ocean waves against the shore.

--

Green light, black dirt, a mouthful of blood; Catra's hands around the hilt of her sword, her shirt in tatters. Adora's eyes, wide and full of fear. A flash of gold, a deep-voiced laugh, a wave of red sweeping across her vision -

Catra jerks awake, sitting bolt upright in her narrow bed. She's breathing in harsh gasps, her body sore and covered in sweat.

The room gradually comes into focus around her, calming her; white and gold, a warm wash of sunlight pouring in through the window. It's early morning still: Catra can hear the singing of the birds.

"Catra?" Adora says, and Catra whips around to face her, driven by pure reflex. As soon as she realizes her mistake, Catra burns with shame. She tangles her arms in the sheets, curling into herself.

Adora holds out her palm, lowered like a white flag, and slides to the end of her bed until they're within an arm's length from each other. "It's okay," she says. "You're safe. Can I touch you?"

Catra nods. Adora reaches out slowly, placing a hand on top of Catra's own, and Catra lets herself lean into the grounding force of the touch.

"Sorry," she mumbles, shamefaced. "Nightmare."

"It's okay," Adora repeats. "I get them, too. After what we've been through, it's normal."

Catra blows out a long breath, trying to recover herself. If she blinks, she can still see the afterimages of green light etched into the backs of her eyelids. All of a sudden, the room feels stiflingly small.

"Can we go for a walk?" she asks. "I know it's still early, but I - I need fresh air."

"Of course," Adora says, and now there's a spark dancing in her eyes. "Are you sure you want to *walk,* though?"

--

Twenty minutes later, Catra and Adora are riding through the woods on a pair of horses. Catra's is a brown pinto mare, Adora's a pure white stallion with an oddly red mane.

Catra clutches to the reins tightly, eyeing her horse with distaste. It seems placid enough so far, but she doesn't trust it. Whatever else might have happened in the past, she's pretty sure that she's never liked riding.

"You're not going to fall," Adora says, and Catra scoffs.

"How do you know?" she asks. "Did the horse tell you itself? Cause if not, I'm not going to take your word for it."

Adora laughs, the sound swallowed by the thick foliage surrounding them. Catra relaxes slightly; despite the untrustworthy horse, the morning is a good one. The sky is a clear blue, the sun hot on her back, the leaves a perfect emerald green; when she inhales, the air carries a sweet promise of summertime peace. She glances over at Adora, who's smiling as she pushes her horse into a trot, and shakes off the remainder of her nightmare like it's just one more memory her mind can't hold onto.

"Are you feeling better?" Adora asks, glancing over at her now, a hint of concern creeping into her voice.

"Yes," Catra says, and she means it.

The set of Adora's shoulders softens visibly, and Catra blushes; Adora seems to really *care* about her, in an unfamiliar way that makes Catra's chest fill with warmth.

"Want to have a race, then?" Adora says, one eyebrow arching upwards, the gleam back in her eyes now.

Catra grins back at her. Without another word, she kicks her horse gently in the sides. It begins to gallop, leaving Adora behind in the dust.

"Hey!" Adora calls out. "Cheater!"

Her horse breaks into a gallop too, quickly catching up to Catra; they race neck and neck down the narrow path until they burst into a clearing. Catra's horse beats Adora's by a step, edging past her into the grass.

"I won," she says smugly, smirking at Adora.

"You won by *cheating,"* Adora huffs, but she's laughing. A strand of hair falls loose over her forehead, and without thinking, Catra reaches out and smoothes it back, letting her hand rest against Adora's temple for a moment longer. A dull pink flush creeps across the tops of Adora's cheekbones, but she doesn't pull away.

“Oh,” she says a moment later, seeming to realize where they are.

Catra looks around, taking in their surroundings. The clearing is large, a perfect sphere of space carved out in the midst of the trees: bare dirt edged with grass, half-ringed with standing stones on the left side.

Adora dismounts from her horse and walks slowly into the center of the clearing, her expression sobering. Catra dismounts too, following her.

“It’s weird that we ended up here,” Adora murmurs. “I didn’t even realize.”

Catra tips her head to one side, listening. The birdsong has gone quiet, and the breeze has stopped blowing. The clearing is the picture of idyll, but there’s something sinister lurking beneath the surface, something that speaks of battle and bloodshed. She gets the feeling that she’s stood in this very spot before, bent beneath the weight of impossible odds.

“Where are we?” she asks.

“The Glade of Serenity,” Adora says. Her voice is hushed, as if speaking too loudly will summon an unseen enemy. “We fought Prime here - among other places. I guess you could call this the scene of our last stand.”

Catra still can’t remember the fight, but she remembers the feeling; the menacing stillness of the glade works its way beneath her skin, making her shiver.

Adora gazes into the distance, her expression troubled. Catra reaches for her hand, the touch a reminder that she’s still here.

“Sorry,” Adora says, turning to face her now, the corner of her mouth a soft crease. “I know I’m dwelling on the past. I just can’t help feeling like there’s something left of Prime here.”

“I know what you mean,” Catra says, her gaze flicking around the clearing in futile search of a threat. She sees nothing, but still the sense of danger lingers in the air around them.

Adora lets their hands drop, their fingers still interlaced, and takes a step closer to Catra, pressing their foreheads together. Catra forgets about the clearing, forgets about the danger, forgets about anything other than Adora.

“I didn’t know how to breathe without you,” Adora whispers. “I don’t want to ever lose you again.”

“You won’t,” Catra says, and the words fall from her lips with the weight of a promise.

A tear brims in the corner of Adora’s eye, and Catra brushes it away with her thumb. She leans up and presses a kiss to Adora’s forehead, no longer concerned with crossing lines; she knows now that they transcend boundaries. They always have.

Driven by an inexplicable force, Catra drops to one knee, then draws her sword and places it flat on her palms, the keen edge of the blade resting against her skin. She holds it up to Adora: an offering, an oath.

“I won’t leave you again,” Catra says. “Even if Prime himself rises again and tries to tear us apart.”

Adora takes the sword from her, holding it easily, her grip on the hilt perfect. “You did this for me once before,” she says. “You promised we would win the battle. Do you remember?”

Catra bows her head. “No,” she answers. “I don’t.” She tries to reach for the memory, but it’s not there; she reaches farther, and her head is overwhelmed with an agonizing ache, pain sweeping through her mind relentlessly, a tidal wave of hurt obliterating her half-formed thoughts -

The wind picks up suddenly, howling around them. Across the clearing, the standing stones begin to glow with a harsh white

light. The sky goes dark, green lightning arcing across the splintered heavens.

Adora's eyes are glowing green now, trails of viridescent emerald spreading through her veins. She shakes her head violently, as if trying to dislodge something. Catra looks up at her, and it's as if someone else is staring back at her from Adora's eyes. For the first time ever, when she looks at Adora, Catra is afraid of what she sees.

"No," Adora screams, pressing one hand to her forehead. "No, please, *please* - " Her eyes shift from green to grey, until it's just Adora, scared and desperate.

"Adora," Catra says, her words half-lost in the shrieking howl of the wind. "Try to hang on, you can fight this - "

Adora's eyes turn green once more, her teeth bared in a grimace, blood spreading over the corner of her mouth. She grips Catra's sword tighter, her knuckles white against the hilt.

"You don't remember," Adora says, her voice low and dangerous and filled with agony. *"Why don't you remember?"*

"I'm sorry," Catra cries out. "I'm *sorry!"*

"Me too," Adora says, and she lifts the sword and drives it straight into Catra's chest.

Catra clutches uselessly at the wound, her entire body an explosion of pain. She bleeds out on the field of a battle she doesn't remember fighting, and as the last seconds of her life drain away between her bloodied fingers, she sees Adora standing over her with an expression of violent devotion written across her face. There's a darkness filling her vision now, an endless pitch black ocean of a sky, her mouth filling with salt water -

The tide washes over Catra's head, pulling her under. She slips beneath the waves without a fight.

:::

(THE SEVENTH GATE)

A sunlit beach, a faded walkway:

Catra sits at the edge of the boardwalk, her back resting against the age-worn driftwood planks, her bare feet half buried under the warm, sugar-white sand. Above her, the sun blazes down hotly, drenching the beach in a hazy warmth that turns the water a brilliant turquoise, the tips of the gentle waves crested with a sparkling gleam. The beach bakes in the heat, a slow and welcome burn that feels like a caress from summer itself.

Past the dusty parking lot, the coast spreads itself out in a long, winding curve of green and sandy brown. Catra can see the red roofs of a town in the distance, following the curl of a hill, and behind that, the tops of skyscrapers reaching upwards into the endless blue: a small coastal city. She lives there, she thinks; oddly, she can't quite remember.

She concentrates for a moment, sliding her sunglasses down to block out the glare so she can focus. The name pops into her head: *Etheria.* She's at the beach just outside Etheria City, where she lives, and it's early in the morning on a Wednesday afternoon in late July.

Catra has no idea why this took her so long to remember this. She grudgingly admits to herself that maybe she had a few too many margaritas the previous night.

She adjusts her sunglasses and looks around again.

Farther down the beach, she can see the multicolored canopies of umbrellas rising above the sand. A few small groups of people sit clustered along the beach: mothers in sundresses trading gossip, young children chasing each other in and out of the water, three tired-looking teenagers sunbathing on shared towels.

The only person who seems to be here alone is Catra herself.

"Hey," says a voice from behind her.

Catra turns to see a tall woman standing there, her blonde hair damp with salt, her eyes a lively shade of grey that shine as brightly as the sun's reflection on the waves. She's wearing a black bikini top and a pair of red lifeguard shorts with a pair of cheap plastic sunglasses hanging from one of the pockets, and she's carrying a shortboard under one arm.

She's absolutely gorgeous, and it knocks the breath right out of Catra's lungs.

"Uh," Catra says eloquently, wishing that she could think of something more intelligent to say, wishing that the sleeveless shirt with the faded band logo and the ragged pair of cutoffs she's wearing weren't the same clothes from last night. "Hi."

"What are you doing here?" the woman asks, and Catra's brain scrambles; she doesn't understand what kind of existential bullshit question is that, doesn't understand what right does this woman have to ask her this, doesn't understand why she can't *remember* what exactly she's doing here -

Doesn't understand why the response that immediately springs to her lips, the reflex as natural as breathing, is *waiting for you.*

"Oh, sorry," the woman adds. "That came out kinda wrong. I didn't mean to like, interrogate you or anything. I was just wondering, because the boardwalk isn't open yet."

She waves a hand towards the crowded mess of shops that line the back of the boardwalk, painted in bright shades of pink and

yellow, and Catra realizes that she's right: none of them are open yet, except for one small building that has an OPEN sign in the window. The writing above the door reads: *Paradise Diner.*

"Wrong," Catra says, looking up at her smugly. "The diner's open."

The woman glances in the direction that Catra's pointing. "Oh, yeah. Forgot about that." She shuffles her feet in the sand, a restless gesture. "Sorry, I know this is weird. I just saw you sitting over here and thought *wow, she's pretty, I need to talk to her,* but I'm kind of bad at small talk. And I'm realizing that I kind of sound insane right now." She laughs awkwardly, running a hand through her hair.

"You kind of do," Catra agrees. And then, because she's not a total jerk and this woman is unmistakably the hottest person she's ever met, she adds: "Want to make it up to me over waffles?"

A smile breaks out on the woman's face, bright and curving. Catra's heart stumbles over itself at the sight, the beats coming fast and irregular.

"Sounds good," the woman says. "My name is Adora, by the way."

Adora, Catra thinks. *Adora.* She turns the name over in her mouth, parsing it for something she doesn't understand. Her mind feels heavy, her thoughts sluggish: heat-drunk, liquor-hazed. She shakes her head to clear out the cobwebs.

"I'm Catra," she says. "Nice to meet you."

Adora holds out a hand, and Catra lets herself be pulled to her feet. Their fingers remain joined for a second too long, and Catra thinks she can almost feel the ghost of something filling the space around them: an echo, an imprint.

"Okay," Adora says, dropping her hand and taking something from the ridiculously large pockets of her shorts - a white t-shirt, which she puts on. "Let's go." Her voice hitches a little, and Catra briefly

wonders if she feels it too: this thing between them, this strange familiarity.

"Lead the way," she answers, carefully keeping her voice steady.

--

They sit in the window booth of the diner overlooking the boardwalk, and past that, the ocean. The table is sticky beneath their elbows, and the pale yellow walls are covered in faded postcards from places all over the world; the floor is made from smooth wooden planks and liberally scattered with sand. The diner feels worn at the edges, softened by time and love, comfortable as a Sunday morning.

"Have you ever been here?" Adora asks, and Catra regretfully shakes her head.

Adora grins. "Oh, you're in for a treat. I come here almost every morning. The owner said they might as well build me a room in the back." She hands Catra a menu, flipping her own open at the same time. "I usually have the waffles and hash browns, but the western omelette is amazing too."

"Western omelette?" Catra arches an eyebrow at her. "What are you, a horse girl?"

Adora glances away, pointedly avoiding her gaze. A laugh spills from Catra's throat, louder than she intended. "Oh my god. You *are* a horse girl, aren't you."

"No!" Adora says. "I used to ride when I was in middle school, that's all."

Catra smirks. "Whatever you say, horse girl."

"Shut up," Adora mumbles, hiding behind her menu. "Just order your waffles and stop teasing me."

“No can do, princess,” Catra replies. “Teasing you is my civic duty.”

Adora drops her menu again, revealing that her face is now pink. “Shut *up* ,” she repeats, blushing prettily, one hand stretching across the table to smack Catra softly on the wrist; Catra takes the hit like it’s nothing, like they’ve been bantering over breakfast at the diner for a lifetime’s worth of summer mornings. Like it’s exactly where they belong.

They order waffles and hash browns and orange juice, and Adora builds a house out of sugar packets while they wait. Catra watches her in amusement.

“You know that thing is going to fall over at any moment, right?”

Adora stacks another packet on. “Shut up, it’s fine.”

“I can literally see it tipping as we speak.”

“It’s *not* going to tip - ”

Catra narrows her eyes, glaring at the flimsy structure. As if in response, the sugar packets crumble into a pile next to Adora’s hand.

“Told you.”

“Asshole,” Adora says, the corner of her mouth curling upwards despite herself. She tosses a cream cup at Catra, who easily ducks.

The waitress approaches their table, her expression grim. “Sorry,” she says, “but we can’t actually serve you any food, because the idiot new kid we hired forgot to close the fridges last night and now everything’s spoiled.” She glares over her shoulder at a scrawny blond boy, who cowers behind the counter. “You’ll have to find breakfast somewhere else. I’m so sorry.”

"Ah, it's okay," Adora says, getting to her feet. "We'll get along just fine. I'll be back tomorrow morning."

"I know you will," the waitress says, giving her a quick smile. "Can't say the same about *him,* though."

The waitress waves as they leave, and Catra follows Adora down the boardwalk until they reach the beach parking lot. Adora heads straight for a rundown jeep, and Catra scoffs. Of course she has a jeep.

"So," Adora says, throwing her shortboard into the back of the car. "I guess I didn't get you any waffles after all. Sorry about that."

Catra shrugs. "It's fine. It's not your fault that shrimpy blond kid fucked everything up."

"I guess," Adora says. "Anyway, I should probably get going." She pauses, clears her throat, fiddles with her key lanyard. "Um. Unless you want to come with?"

Catra knows she shouldn't say yes. She knows that half an hour on opposite sides of a diner table isn't nearly long enough to judge someone's character; she knows that getting into a stranger's car, even a stranger as hot as Adora, is a terrible idea that could end in any number of graphically tragic ways. But she's twenty-one and it's July, and the endless possibility of summer is blooming around her like a flower unfurling, and the crooked curve of Adora's mouth makes Catra's heart beat right out of her chest.

"Okay," she says, imagining a roll of the dice. Adora smiles at her - double sixes, all the luck in the world. "Yeah. I'll come with you."

Adora opens the passenger side door for her, and Catra vaults up into the jeep with a neat jump. The seat is warm and soft beneath her, frayed fabric half-bleached out from days in the sun.

Adora gets in on the other side and starts the engine, fiddling with the dial of the ancient radio; there's a blur of static, a crackling

hum of white noise, and then a country song spills out of the speakers, the twang of the notes like the sticky sweetness of honeyed tea.

Catra groans. “Seriously? Country? You’re taking the horse girl thing too far.”

Adora just winks at her and starts backing out of the parking lot. “I’m sure I don't know what you’re talkin’ about, partner,” she drawls, tipping an imaginary hat. It’s stupidly endearing; against her will, Catra is charmed by it.

“So where are we going, anyway?” she asks as they pull onto the main road.

Adora glances over at her, smiling lopsidedly, and the imperfect beauty of it stuns Catra into silence. Wind whips through the open windows, ruffling their hair, carrying the smell of sea salt. The open road lies before them, curving along the coastline, an entire universe drawn along those two yellow lines.

“Where are we going?” Adora says. “Anywhere.”

--

Anywhere turns out to be a large thrift store tucked in the middle of a sprawling strip mall just outside the edge of the city. The parking lot is hot, the asphalt slick beneath their feet as they get out of the car, and the fronds of the palm trees scattered throughout the lot wave limply against the heat.

“ *Nirvana Vintage,”* Catra says, tipping her head back to read the sign above the door. “I’ll be honest, I didn’t really take you for the thrifting kind.”

Adora looks offended. “Because you think I’m the kind of person to buy all my clothes new?”

“Because I think you’re not cool enough to wear vintage stuff.”

Adora rolls her eyes, pulls open the door. Catra slides past her into the welcome cool of the shop. An elderly woman behind the counter lowers a magazine long enough to smile at them and offer them help, then returns to reading.

"Okay, fine," Adora says, once they're halfway down the jacket aisle. "Usually I don't go to thrift stores a lot, but today I need to because there's this big midsummer formal dinner I have to go to for work and I don't have a dress for it."

"I won't be much help here, you know," Catra says, flipping through a rack of belts. "The last time I wore a dress was in middle school, and that was only because I was forced to."

Adora starts grabbing armfuls of dresses from the formal wear section. "I'm going to go start trying things on. Just tell me if anything looks good."

Catra follows her to the back of the store. Adora heads for the changing rooms, and Catra settles down to wait; she wanders over to the shelves full of miscellaneous objects, sorting through them absentmindedly. The sign over her head has *$5 for 5 Items* scrawled in bright red ink.

There's a wide array of things on the shelves: baseball cards, toy cars, carved wooden napkin rings, toy animal figurines, a tattered copy of *Romeo and Juliet,* a box of assorted erasers, and a tangle of grubby friendship bracelets, all covered in a thin layer of dust.

Catra picks up *Romeo and Juliet,* flipping through the pages idly. To her surprise, something falls out, drifting down to the floor. She bends over to pick it up.

It's a set of two tarot cards, stuck together at the edges. Catra pulls them apart gently and holds them up to the light.

When she sees their designs, something tightens in her chest.

THE WARRIOR, one of them says: it depicts a tall blonde woman in white and gold battle armor, her face mostly obscured by a

protective headpiece that matches the design of the other woman's mask. She's raising a sword, and even though her features are indistinct, Catra feels a strange sense of recognition curling around the base of her spine.

THE LOVER, the other one says: it has a shorter woman on it, a woman with a red mask. She's surrounded by shadows, reaching for a single golden star above her.

Catra stares at the cards, her heart hammering painfully, a sickly feeling working its way through her head. She knows that there's something important about this, something that rings a vague and distant bell -

"Hey," Adora says, and Catra flinches, spinning around to face her. "What do you think of this one?"

Catra looks her up and down, taking in the dress that she's wearing - a bold crimson with hints of lighter red - and for a moment, she forgets all about the cards. Adora's hair is falling in messy golden waves, and the dress clings to her curves in a way that makes Catra's pulse stutter in her chest, her wrists, her throat.

"I, uh," Catra says, all too aware that she's stammering. "Yeah. That one. Looks good."

"Are you sure?"

"Yes."

Adora's mouth curls with amusement. "Watch out," she says. "A reaction like that...I might get the impression that you like me."

Catra scoffs. "What? I don't like you."

"Keep telling yourself that," Adora grins. She leans over, looking curiously at the cards in Catra's hand. "What have you got there?"

“Oh, I found these old tarot cards,” Catra says, passing them to her. “There’s something weird about them, don’t you think? I don’t know why, but they make me feel kind of...I don’t even know how to describe it, it’s just - ”

Adora studies the cards for a moment, then shrugs. “I don’t know, I think these are pretty standard for a tarot deck, right? I mean, it’s just the sun and the moon.”

Catra frowns in confusion, taking the cards back. “No, it’s - ”

She stops dead in the middle of her sentence, staring at the cards in disbelief. They now read THE SUN and THE MOON, showing a golden sun and a silver crescent moon against starlit skies.

An ache begins to bloom at the corner of Catra’s temple. The cards were different, she knows that - but now she can’t remember what they were before.

“Yeah,” she says, shrugging it off. “Whatever. They’re just dumb cards. Ready to go?”

By the time they slide back into Adora’s car, the seats burning beneath them and the pavement shimmering in the heat as they pull out of the lot, Catra’s almost forgotten about the sense of unease that the cards gave her. Any lingering concern disappears when Adora turns to her, hair a windblown mess and eyes bright with happiness.

“Do you have somewhere else to be?” Adora asks. “There’s one more place I’d like to take you.”

Catra raises an eyebrow. “One more place you’d like to take me? Careful there, princess. You’re almost making this sound like a date.”

Adora blushes. “I didn’t mean - ”

“I know what you meant,” Catra says, tipping her seat back. “I have nowhere else to be. I’m down.”

The only place I have to be , she thinks, watching Adora sing along to the song on the radio, *is by your side.*

--

Adora pulls the car to a stop, and Catra stares out the window at the cluster of buildings before them: brick and glass and steel, and the pure white limestone that Bright Moon University is known for.

"Breaking and entering at the local college," Catra says appreciatively. "Pretty good for a first date, I have to say."

"We're not *breaking,"* Adora says. "We're just entering. I have a key."

"Boring. I say we break in anyway, just for fun." Catra glances around. "What are we here for, anyway?"

Adora just smiles. "You'll see."

They set out on a tile path that cuts through the heart of campus, passing administration buildings and lecture halls and the green swathe of the quad. Adora leads her to an area behind the soccer fields, where a tall building with opaque walls sits next to a residence hall.

"One of my friends is a botany major," Adora explains as she unlocks the door of the greenhouse, "and she's on the Agriculture Committee, so greenhouse care is part of her responsibilities, but she gave me the spare key just in case she ever needs me to water the plants or something."

Catra steps forward into the greenhouse. For a minute, all she can do is stare.

The greenhouse is warm and humid, the air filled with the sweet scent of a hundred different flowers. Plants are *everywhere* : on tables, on benches, in rows on the floor. In one corner, ivy climbs a lattice of trellises; in another, massive leaves shaped like

elephant ears rise halfway to the ceiling. Flowers bloom across every available surface, turning the room into a riot of colors in every shade imaginable.

Adora nudges her. “What do you think? Pretty good, right?”

Catra blinks. “Yeah. I’m not some hippie plant lover, but...wow. This is awesome.”

“There’s a table,” Adora says, pointing towards the back of the room. “Sit down if you want, open one of the windows. I’m going to bring you something.”

Catra sits down at the small gardener’s table, pushing open the small window next to it and inhaling the fresh breeze that comes rushing through. Adora disappears behind a thicket of sunflowers, humming to herself.

“Do you go here?” Catra calls over to her. “BMU, I mean.”

“Yeah, I’m in the College of Arts and Humanities. Communications. You?”

“I’m in pre-law,” Catra answers, leaning back against the wall. “Weird that we’ve never met before, isn't it? The campus isn’t that big.”

“I don’t know,” Adora says. “Maybe we were just meant to meet today.”

Catra wants to laugh this off as ridiculous, but something about it rings true. It doesn’t quite feel like she was supposed to meet Adora today - instead, it feels like they’ve known each other for years. It feels like today is a reunion instead of a first meeting, like all the time she’d lived through before finding Adora was a mere comma between two parts of a half-written sentence.

And Catra, who disdains romantic comedies, who thinks that soulmates are stupid, who scorns the idea of fate, says: “Maybe we were.”

“I’m coming back,” Adora says, and there’s a rustling noise. “Close your eyes.”

Catra closes her eyes, feeling something brush against her hand. When she opens them again, Adora is sitting across from her, and Catra’s hands are full of flowers.

An entire bouquet blossoms between her fingers in shades of pink and gold and orange and lavender. The air smells like honey and vanilla, sweet and delicate. It’s all so *beautiful,* and Adora’s just smiling like it was nothing.

“Adora,” Catra says, lost for words. “This is - ”

“The pale purple ones are hyacinths,” Adora says. “The pink ones are carnations, the orange ones are yarrow, the yellow ones are heliotropes.” She grins. “I’ve picked up a little botany over the past few months.”

Catra inhales deeply, imagines the flowers in her hands blooming within her: between her ribs, inside her lungs. Adora smiles at her, and Catra’s heart feels like a sunflower turning towards the light.

“What are the purple ones?”

“Forget-me-nots,” Adora answers. “That’s strange. I didn’t pick any of those. They must have gotten caught up in the carnations.”

“Well,” Catra says, teasing. “I’ll let it slide this one time.”

“Oh!” Adora says, getting to her feet again. “How could I forget? Hold on.”

She reaches over to a tree in a blue pot, and for the first time, Catra notices the large red fruits hanging from the branches. Adora picks one of them carefully, bringing it back to the table and producing a knife from one of the drawers.

“Pomegranates,” she explains. “They just started growing them this year.”

Catra watches as Adora deftly cuts the pomegranate into halves. Red juice drips over the table, staining the wood, and Adora glances at it guiltily.

“Guess I’ll have to bleach this out later,” she says, and then: “Damn. They’re not quite ripe.”

She tips a pomegranate half towards Catra, showing her the pale red color of the seeds. Catra turns over the other half to see that there are six deep crimson seeds nestled in the center of the paler ones, big and perfect.

“There’s some good ones here,” she says. “I’ll take three if you take three?”

“Sounds good,” Adora says. She pries the seeds out carefully and drops three of them into Catra’s palm, where they glitter like rubies. “Bottoms up.”

Catra laughs. “You’re so dumb,” she says, and then pops the seeds into her mouth.

Flavor bursts in her mouth, a sour taste spreading over her tongue, the tartness of the juice like an explosion between her teeth. It tastes like pomegranate, but so much more: it tastes like a field of wildflowers, the turn of the seasons, a decade at war, a meadow full of sunlight, a sky full of stars. It tastes like winters filled with loneliness, and summers full of love. It tastes like forty nights spent waiting at the garden gates. It tastes like life and death itself, and before Catra can even begin to process how this is possible, it vanishes as she swallows.

“Whoa,” Adora says, her eyes wide as she finishes eating. “Those are intense.”

“Yeah,” Catra murmurs, her head hazy. It feels like the past is wrapped around them, years of history binding them together

with unbreakable bonds. For some reason, she almost wants to cry. “Do you feel that?”

“I think so,” Adora says, tilting her head quizzically. She presses a hand to the corner of her mouth, wincing. “Ow. I definitely feel *that.”*

Catra leans forward, concerned. “What happened?”

“Bit myself by accident. It’s fine.”

Blood trickles from the edge of Adora’s lip, mingling with the pomegranate juice. Catra reaches out to gently run her fingers along the wound; Adora sighs, leaning into the touch. There’s panic fluttering between Catra’s ribs at the sight of Adora’s injury, a sharp-edged concern that runs far deeper than a simple cut.

“You’re such an idiot,” Catra says. “You should be more careful. Look out for yourself, or I’ll do it for you.”

Adora smiles at her, crooked and beautiful. “Is that a threat or a promise?”

“Both.”

“How about this,” Adora says, catching Catra’s hand, lacing their fingers together. “I’ll look out for you if you look out for me.”

“You promise?” Catra asks, and it’s like the world stops spinning; the universe pauses, waits at the edge of their breaths. They’re the only two people alive right now, and she knows it like she knows her own name. Like she knows Adora’s face.

Adora’s eyes meet Catra’s, blue and yellow against grey: the sea. the sun, the stars. Their hands are still joined.

“I promise,” Adora says softly.

Catra inhales sharply, her mind suddenly flooded with memories. She tries to hold on, to ground herself in this moment, but she’s

swept away.

Narrow beds, cold halls, a rooftop -

Adora's voice: "Catra?"

A hand in hers, bruises and battles, nightmares and daydreams -

"Catra - "

A red mask, a winged crest, a white shirt with red markings -

The wind picking up, the plants rustling -

A skiff, a sword, a hand falling from hers -

The window slamming closed -

A bright white light, a shattered world, a bitter fight -

The glass shattering -

A world of green, an ocean of pain, a pair of grey eyes meeting hers -

"Catra!"

A crumbling room, a broken heart, a terrible silence -

The sky is dark now, the greenhouse roof torn away, but all Catra can concentrate on is Adora. She grips her hand tighter, presses hard against skin and bone; it's solid, it's real, it's *her.*

"I remember," Catra says, staring directly into Adora's eyes. The wind is whipping around them like a tornado, like it did before: on the bridge, in the field. "I remember you."

Lightning rips through the sky, striking between them as thunder crashes like tidal waves. The earth shakes beneath their feet, dragging them back, pulling them down until they're brought to their knees.

Catra clutches Adora's hand tighter, until she can feel the hot burn of blood dripping between their fingers.

"I won't let go," Catra shouts, and she's not sure if she's talking to Adora or to the underworld itself.

"I won't either," Adora yells back, and it's enough - it's finally enough, she's finally going to stay -

Catra closes her eyes, every siren of the storm suddenly silent around her. She's standing in a meadow, sunlight spilling across the field of flowers, and Adora is standing next to her, their foreheads pressed together.

"Catra," Adora says softly: a question, a promise.

"Adora," Catra answers, her voice a dying whisper, and the universe explodes around them, tearing the sky and earth apart, scattering them like shrapnel from space.

Catra's consciousness fades, her heart faltering in her chest, her descent blazing across the sky like the path of a fallen star. The last sensation she's aware of is a hand in hers and a stinging pain in her palm, a crescent-sharp slice against the curve of her heartline.

--

Catra opens her eyes and instantly regrets it.

She's lying on a rocky stretch of land, pebbles digging into her back. Every bone in her body aches, and her muscles feel torn and ragged. Her head rings, and stars dance across her vision when she blinks.

Memories start to return to her: the Hall of Judgement, the Fates, the ice cave, the bridges, the spaceship, the kingdom, the beach. Adora's mouth, pressed against hers in the light of a starfield. Adora's hand, on the hilt of a sword thrust through Catra's chest.

Catra's left hand throbs, and it's only then that she realizes she's holding something so tightly it's bleeding her knuckles dry; she turns her head to see Adora lying next to her, their hands locked tightly together. Adora's forehead is littered with bleeding cuts, her hair a tangled mess of golden knots, and her eyes are closed tightly.

"Adora," Catra says, fear rising in her throat. "Adora, wake up." She pulls her hand from Adora's, shakes it to get the blood circulating again. Then she places it on Adora's shoulder and starts shaking her. "Adora, I swear to fucking god, if you die on me - if you die on me *again* - "

Adora's eyes flutter open slowly, and Catra almost chokes on a breath of relief. She pulls Adora to her chest in a tight hug, disregarding the way that her body aches with the movement.

"Ow," Adora mutters, pulling back. "Shit. Where are we?"

"It's you, right?" Catra says, staring anxiously into her eyes. "You're really here?"

Adora's gaze softens for a moment. "Yeah," she says. "I'm really here." She glances around. "Although I wish I wasn't.
Where *are* we?"

Catra looks around for the first time, and her stomach clenches like a fist.

They're at the bottom of a valley. Mountains range around them on two sides, ominous peaks that carve at the sky like teeth. Far in the distance, the hills that rise in front of them are made of a dark and pitted stone, sharp and unforgiving; behind them, a river of black, poisonous-looking water flows past the foothills and into the distance. Trees grow around the valley, scattered between rocks and stumps, their branches gnarled, their leaves covered in parasitic growths and thorny brambles. Above them, strange winged creatures call to each other in harsh screeches, drifting back and forth on the updrafts.

Craters cover the surface of the valley, filled with something that looks like lava. As Catra watches, the nearest one bursts open, spitting something out onto the ground: a winged creature, a miniature version of the ones in the sky. Before they can do anything, the thing spits in their direction and crawls off into the trees.

"This is not good," Adora says. "It's weird here. It feels *wrong.* It's nothing like where I was before."

"Where *were* you before?"

Adora shrugs hopelessly. "I don't know, exactly. But it was warm and bright, and I don't think I was alone...I wasn't happy, exactly, but I knew that I was somewhere safe."

"Well, sorry for dragging you away from paradise," Catra snaps, guilt and anger surging in her chest. She replays Adora's words, and a spike of pain rips through her as she realizes what Adora is saying. "You don't - you don't remember space? Or the kingdom, or - "

Adora shakes her head slowly. "I'm sorry. I don't. What happened?"

Catra's heart folds in on itself, curling into darkness along with her last hope of a better life with Adora.

"Nothing," she says, forcing her voice to remain steady. "Whatever. Let's find a way out of here."

Adora stares towards the hills in the distance, charting the rise and fall of their shapes. She points to a pinprick of light atop a knoll, barely visible in the poor light.

"There," she says. "That tower. That's where we need to go."

Catra squints and catches a split-second glimpse: a tall obelisk, a golden flash against the leaden line of the sky.

“Okay, then,” she says. “Let’s move.”

--

They walk for what feels like hours, an uneasy silence settling between them. Catra can barely keep her eyes off Adora; she glances over every few seconds, reassuring herself that she’s still here, but looks away the second Adora tries to make eye contact.

It’s not that Catra doesn’t want conversation. She *wants* to talk to Adora; she wants it so badly that her mouth is bleeding from biting the words back so many times. But she can’t bring herself to speak, because she doesn’t know how to vocalize any of the things she wants to say. Every half-finished sentence that springs to mind is a futile contrivance, a lesson in failure.

She wants to say *I’m glad you’re here.* She wants to say *I hate you for dying.* She wants to say *I hate you for forgetting.* She wants to say *I love you.*

She says none of it. She walks with her back straight and her shoulders taut with tension, and she doesn’t reach for Adora even though she’s longing to.

The knoll draws closer, the obelisk growing bigger in their line of sight, until they’re only a hillside away and it’s rising above them, casting them in shadow. Catra studies the towering line of the monument, eyes fixed firmly to the shining sides of stone.

Finally, Adora breaks the silence.

“I can’t believe you came here for me,” she says, and her tone isn’t amazed or affectionate or even grateful; it’s dull and flat, heavy with an emotion that Catra can’t decipher.

“Why are you saying it like that?” Catra asks, angry. “Stop acting like it’s just another horrible thing I’ve done. I’m trying to *save* you.”

“It was too dangerous,” Adora retorts, and there’s a flash in her eyes: a storm, building before it breaks. “You aren’t meant to survive down here - you could have been hurt, you could have died.”

“Like you did, you mean?” Catra says, and Adora flinches. “What, so you can die for Etheria but I’m not good enough to die for you?”

“That’s not what I meant, Catra. I was already dead.”

Catra halts in her tracks, bringing them both to a stop. She puts a hand to Adora’s chest, slowly, deliberately, fingers pressed to the flutter of life at the base of her throat. The touch shivers through both of them.

“You’re not dead,” Catra says.

Adora pulls away from her. “I should be. I died at the Heart, okay? That’s how it was supposed to go. I died, and Etheria was saved. Nobody else was supposed to end up in danger after that. Especially - ” She pauses. “Especially not you.”

Catra laughs bitterly, the sound scraping up the back of her throat like a wound. The same old path, the same old trap. It’s like they’re running around in circles.

“You don’t have to die for everyone,” she says tiredly. The first time they’d had this conversation, she’d been outraged; now, she’s just exhausted. “The world might have needed saving this time, but you’d already put your life on the line long before then. Aren’t you tired of dying for love, Adora? You don’t have to make yourself a martyr all the time.”

She expects Adora to be angry, to shout at her. Instead, Adora just shakes her head.

“What if that’s all I know how to do?” she asks, her voice a painful whisper.

“Of course it’s not,” someone says.

Catra freezes, every instinct in her body screaming to run. Suddenly she’s a little kid again, hiding in a crawl space, hiding within herself, begging for the pain to stop. She manages to catch Adora’s gaze, and seeing the horror in Adora’s eyes is like looking into a mirror.

Shadow Weaver stands on the hill between them and the obelisk, blocking their way. Her mask is gone, revealing an unnerving grin on her damaged face.

“Adora,” she says, extending a hand like she’s reaching for a weapon. “You’ve found me at last. Join me, and together we will rule this place.”

--

The three of them stand still for a minute, staring at each other: Adora and Catra in shock, Shadow Weaver in delight. Catra wants to grab Adora’s hand, but there’s still a part of her that curls up in paralyzing fear at the thought of showing outright affection in front of Shadow Weaver.

She tries to push it down. They’re not in the Fright Zone anymore, and Shadow Weaver is dead.

Not dead enough, though.

“What the fuck are you doing here?” Catra demands. “You died. We watched you die.”

“So I did,” Shadow Weaver says with a shrug. She turns to Adora. “But you did too, didn’t you? And here you are.”

Adora’s eyes are wide. “Shadow Weaver - what’s happening? Why are you here?”

“I thought it was obvious. I’m here to free you from the clutches of this distracting nuisance and take you to a place where we can

be all-powerful." Shadow Weaver waves a hand around at the bleak landscape. "I already control all of this. Soon, with your help, we can take over the entire underworld."

"You're insane," Catra spits at her. "If you think either of us would help us after everything you've done - "

"After I died for you, you mean?"

It hits home, even though Catra wishes it didn't; she sees Adora wince, and knows she feels it too.

"Look, Adora," Shadow Weaver says. "You died for a noble cause. Don't you want to live for another one? We could take over this place. We could fix it. No more pain, no more suffering. Just a kingdom of peace and rest for departed souls. We could save so many people, and it would be all because of you."

Adora hesitates. Catra wants to scream *don't trust her,* but her voice is caught in her throat like a bird trapped in a cage.

"You want me to leave Catra behind," Adora says. A statement, not a question.

"Yes. What has she ever done for you? You've always been held back by her." Shadow Weaver's eyes gleam red. "She's been a distraction. A failure. A useless burden. She's always been your weakness, Adora. Without her, you could be so much more."

Adora inhales deeply, and for the space of a broken heartbeat, Catra thinks she's going to leave. Then her expression hardens into resolve.

"No," she says. "I'm not going to leave her ever again. And I'm definitely not going to trust you."

"Adora," Catra murmurs. "You - "

Shadow Weaver glares at her. "You ungrateful fool. I've offered you the chance of a lifetime, and you're spurning it all for some

ragged disaster of an unwanted stray. I should've drowned her years ago." There's malice glittering red in her eyes, searching for weakness. "You both ate the pomegranate seeds, didn't you? You'll lose three years of your life for that, you know, if you go back."

Catra inhales sharply. She should've known better, should've remembered Micah's warning. The loss of three years seems almost unbearable, but she looks at Adora - still brave, still defiant - and she is not afraid.

"I don't want the *chance* of a lifetime," Adora says, her voice high and clear. "I just want a lifetime, however long it may be." She raises a hand, and even without the Sword of Protection, the gesture carries an authoritative threat. "Now get out of our way."

"Fine," Shadow Weaver says, menacing. "I tried to play nice, but I guess we'll have to do this the hard way." She eyes Adora coldly. "Just remember - when she suffers, it will be on your head."

Shadow Weaver raises her arms. From all around the valley, darkness comes rushing towards them; shadows and shades, curling around the ends of her hands, slowly morphing into human shapes until they're solid matter: wood and stone, iron and bone.

"Remember," Shadow Weaver says. "This is what you wanted."

She flicks her hands, and the army of shadows starts towards them, flowing effortlessly across the jagged ground.

Catra turns to Adora. There's no more fear left in her; instead, there's a blinding rush of defiance that burns like a wildfire in her chest.

"It's been a while since we fought together, right?" she says. "About time we got around to doing it again."

Adora's eyes are shining now, the same sparkle that used to fill her eyes whenever they raced or wrestled or stole rations from

the mess hall. She grins at Catra - crooked and cocky, but somehow still soft - and Catra's heart ties itself into a knot, strands of fate and love weaving together like golden thread. Adora's face is pure confidence, pure bravery, and oh, Catra loves her so much she thinks she might die for this feeling.

No - she thinks she might *live* for it.

"Let's do this," she says, matching Adora's grin.

Together, they rush forward to meet the shadows.

--

They hit the shadow army like a hurricane, tearing through the first row like they're made of nothing but smoke. Catra lashes out with all four limbs, fists punching holes in clay, claws shredding bone. Next to her, Adora is like a lightning strike in a forest. She still can't transform, but she was Etheria's best hand-to-hand combat fighter long before a sword and a tiara made her a hero, and she's showing it now.

Catra stands in the center of the battle and presses her back against Adora's, and they become unstoppable; they move through the shadows, ripping them to pieces until the ground around their feet is littered with shards of iron and rock. They might not have fought together in years, but they fall back into the old ways as if nothing ever changed. It's all instinct, all memory: Adora's blows curving high, Catra's kicks scything low, their punches quicksilver blows that alternate directions like the change of the wind. It's something like a dance, and they've known the steps all their lives.

Shadow Weaver screams, high-pitched, enraged. She raises her arms again, and more shadow warriors appear; they join the fight, piling onto the dead bodies of their comrades without a second's pause.

"You won't escape this time," she screams. "It was a mistake for me to ever waste my time on you."

Catra tries to shout back, can't catch her breath. Her foot slips on a bone, and she begins to fall, but Adora catches her before she's halfway to the ground.

"We don't have to kill them all," Adora says. "We just have to get to the obelisk."

Catra nods, and then a shadow warrior cleaves a slice of skin from her arm and they're back on the defensive. Adora whirls away from her, turns on a tall shadow; Catra balls her fists, springs back to a fighting stance.

Time wears on, minutes passing like drops of blood. They gradually press forward, but every inch is a hard-won victory. Catra's face becomes scratched, her hands bruised. Her arms ache, her legs shake, her lungs reach for air that they can't hold onto. She feels Adora's movements against the curve of her spine and knows that she's just as tired.

More shadows loom over them, blotting out the light, casting them in pitch-black misery, and still they fight on. The obelisk feels like it's miles away, and Catra's knuckles have never been so bloody, and somewhere outside the darkness, Shadow Weaver is laughing in demonic amusement.

Adora stumbles and falls, and she doesn't get up.

Catra drops to her knees, grabbing Adora by the shoulder. There's a towering pile of bone and clay next to them, giving them shelter from the shadows; it's a temporary respite, but Catra grabs it with both hands.

"Adora," Catra says. "Get up. We have to keep going." She drags Adora to her feet until they're both standing again, but Adora slumps against her shoulder as if unwilling to bear her own weight.

"It's useless, Catra," Adora says. "I can't transform, and they just keep coming, and I'm so tired." There's defeat written in the lines

of her face, and a strangling panic shoots through Catra. She's never seen Adora look like this before.

"No," she says fiercely, shaking Adora. "You can't give up, Adora. You *don't* give up. That's who you are."

"Maybe it used to be," Adora mumbles. "I don't know who I am anymore."

Catra presses a hand to Adora's jawline, turns her head until they're face to face. "You're *Adora* ," she says. "You're the worst enemy I've ever had, and the best friend, and you don't give up. You never have. So don't you dare start now." She licks her lips, tastes blood. "Remember when we got the failsafe, when I asked you what you wanted? Don't you want a chance to find out? If anyone deserves that, it's you, Adora."

Adora blinks, surprised. There's something flickering in her eyes: a spark returning, becoming fire. "Yes," she says. "I want that." She reaches over and cradles Catra's face in her hands. "Okay. Alright. If this is my last chance - "

"What - " Catra starts to say.

Adora kisses her.

It's hot and hurried - Adora's mouth warm against Catra's, both of them tasting of blood and pomegranate juice, the crush of their lips like an apocalypse: the end of one world, the start of another. Catra feels it in every part of her soul, feels her heart crashing, burning, exploding into light as time falls away; Adora kisses her like they're rewriting history, like they'll never have the chance again, like they're gods and the universe is newly made.

A radiant glow surrounds them, a brilliant shimmer of light pushing outwards. At first Catra thinks it's a figment of her imagination, but she soon realizes it's not; the shadows are falling back, withering away, until Catra and Adora are left in the center of an open space free of darkness, like nothing can touch them.

Adora pulls away from Catra, smiling at her almost reverently. Her entire body is outlined in golden light. “Wow,” she breathes.

Catra smiles back, no chance of stopping it. “Don’t ruin it.”

The obelisk shines, beckoning like a lighthouse. Catra and Adora turn toward it, ready.

“You insolent scum,” Shadow Weaver shrieks. “You’ll never leave this place alive.”

More shadows gather, swathing the valley in black, blotting out the glow of the obelisk. Adora smirks, raises a hand, yells the words that Catra knows so well: *“For the honor of Greyskull!”*

The Sword of Protection appears in her hand as she transforms, becoming She-Ra once again; she grabs Catra’s hand and slashes through the shadows, the two of them running through the shrouds of darkness as the ground begins to roil beneath their feet and the mountains to their left begin to crumble.

The obelisk. The golden stone. The side looms above Catra, luminous gold as she puts out a hand to touch it.

“No,” Shadow Weaver screams. *“No!”*

She lunges for them, seizing Catra by the ankle, catching her one last time. Adora’s sword moves with deadly speed, slicing through Shadow Weaver like she’s just another shade. The entire valley shakes, disintegrating around them as Catra reaches the obelisk and presses her fingers to the smooth stone.

Everything begins to spin around them, light and dark flashing, day and night merging; time wraps around them, a lifeline around their limbs, a noose around their necks, ships wrecked on stormy seas, planets breaking out of orbit - it’s a thousand years of history, a tale older than time, a starving future come to swallow them whole -

Catra grips Adora's hand as tight as she can. The darkness sweeps them away and they're falling through the center of the cosmos, bruised and bleeding and broken-boned, but finally together.

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(THE SKY)

"...bio signatures are extremely weak…"

"...should we move them?"

"...can't imagine how they're still holding on to each other…"

Catra's awareness returns slowly, in slivers of light, in shards of sound. Familiar voices echo in the distance, filtering through a vast sheet of silence to reach her, but she can only understand a few of their words.

She slowly cracks one eye open, almost blinded by the brightness that comes rushing into her field of vision. She vaguely recognizes the room around her as the interior of Adora's spaceship. With a great effort, she manages to turn her head far enough to see Adora lying next to her on the floor.

As the seconds of consciousness pass, pain floods Catra's body; it sweeps through her, a relentless wave of ceaseless hurt that settles in her bones like it's coming home. Her palm throbs, and she dimly realizes that her right hand still is wrapped in Adora's, their fingers woven tighter than the roots of a willow tree.

Adora's eyes are closed, but she's breathing. Catra watches the faint rise and fall of her chest, the rhythm of her breaths like a waltz: slow and irregular, but undeniable.

Adora's here, Catra realizes. *She's alive.*

Catra's body relaxes, fear bleeding into relief. She allows herself to fall back into oblivion.

--

When Catra's eyes open again, she's lying in a bed surrounded by familiar walls: grey-green metal, precise rivet welds. She sits up, poised to run, but then she pauses. There's something different about this room - it's brighter, warmer, lacking the unforgiving coldness that followed her through the years of her childhood like a shadow. There are windows where walls once were, and morning light is pouring through to bathe the bed in a warm wash of light.

She's in the Fright Zone, but that name doesn't apply anymore.

A shaft of light falls across Catra's sheets, catching on her hands, and she realizes that there's something shining on her palm of her right hand. She looks at it curiously, realizing that there's a blue patch of something that feels like heated metal covering it.

Faint streaks of blood trace around the patch, not quite washed away. Curious, Catra begins to work her claws underneath the edges.

"You probably shouldn't take that off yet."

Catra looks up. Scorpia is standing in the door, her eyes shining with tears, her lips curved into a watery smile.

"Scorpia?" Catra says, and Scorpia begins sobbing loudly.

"Sorry," she says, wiping at her face. "Sorry, I just didn't know if you'd ever come back, and you looked so hurt when they brought you in - oh, wildcat, I thought - "

"Yeah, alright," Catra says, embarrassed. "It's okay, Scorpia. I'm still alive, as you can see." She slides out of bed to prove her

point, but her legs betray her; they bend beneath her weight, pain lancing through her knees.

Scorpia is there in a flash, catching her, wrapping her into a hug that, for once, Catra doesn't try to pull away from immediately. She hugs back, hoping that her apologies are transmitted by touch alone. She doesn't have it in her to vocalize them.

"I'm so glad you're back," Scorpia says, her voice choked with emotion, her arms a little too tight around Catra's bruised ribs.

Catra coughs, disentangling herself. "I'm glad to see you, Scorpia. I really am."

Scorpia cries even more. Catra waits until the worst of it subsides, and then she asks the question that's been weighing on her mind ever since she awoke.

"Where's Adora?"

"She's still asleep," Scorpia says, beckoning for Catra to follow her. "But I can show you where she is, if you want."

--

The room where Adora is sleeping is the old medbay, next to the mess hall. Scorpia quietly slides the door open and steps back to let Catra see.

"I'll let you stay with her for a little while," Scorpia says quietly. "We'll be in the mess hall when you're ready."

It's just the two of them now: one awake, one asleep, both disarmed. Catra leans against the doorframe, watches Adora breathe, counts the seconds between inhale and exhale. She's sleeping peacefully for once, sprawled motionless across the bed, the blankets tangled in a heap across her legs. Even from here, Catra can see the many cuts and bruises painted across the golden canvas of her skin; they match her own, the story of their journey written across their bodies in blood and blemishes.

Catra wants to lie on Adora's floor until she wakes. She wants to crawl into bed next to Adora and curl into her side like they're kids again. She wants and she wants, but she doesn't take. She's taken too much already in her lifetime.

Adora wouldn't mind, says a voice in the back of her mind. *She kissed you, remember? She wants this just as much as you do.*

And Catra wants to believe this, but she knows it can't be true. One kiss shared in the face of death is nothing but a weak foundation, and she's never known how to build something from the ground up. She's half convinced that their recent battle was just another cruel trick played by the underworld, because how could it ever be true? Catra has always wanted, and Adora has never reciprocated, and that's how it will always be. She doesn't know any other version of their story.

Catra takes one last look at Adora, then closes the door soundlessly and walks away down the hall.

--

Glimmer, Bow, Micah, Scorpia, Perfuma, and Entrapta are sitting in the mess hall, talking about something that Catra can't quite catch, and the incongruence of Rebellion leaders in the heart of the Horde makes Catra's head spin a little. Flowers bloom in the corners of the room, spreading around the doorways, filling the boxes below the newly built windows. Perfuma's work, probably.

Catra takes a seat at the end of the table, next to Perfuma. She reminds herself that it's not the Fright Zone anymore.

"Uh," she says, cutting through their conversation. "Hi."

"Catra," Glimmer breathes out, and then she's overturning her chair and sprinting around the table, Bow hot on her heels. The two of them fling themselves onto Catra, crushing her into a hug that pushes the breath out of her lungs.

"Ow," Catra groans, gasping for air. "Glimmer - Bow - *ow* ."

“Sorry,” Bow says, releasing her. There are tears in his eyes, but his smile is so wide that it’s taking over his entire face. “We’re so happy to have you back. We were *so* worried. Glimmer especially.”

“Was not,” Glimmer scoffs. “But I’m glad to see you again, Horde scum.” As Catra watches, Glimmer scrubs roughly at her eyes for a second.

Catra smirks, even though it pulls painfully at the split in her lip. “Are you *crying* , Sparkles?”

Glimmer glares at her. “No.”

“Aw, look at you crying over Horde scum.”

“I’m not crying, asshole!”

“Sure you’re not.”

Perfuma leans across the table, placing a hand lightly on Catra’s arm and smiling in that way she does, like she’s lived a life untouched by sorrow. “I am so glad to see you again, Catra.”

“Yes,” Entrapta adds. “I am extremely pleased that you are still alive, and Adora too. Especially since I had postulated that you had approximately a 0.0022% chance of survival in the underworld, and in the event that you managed to survive, a 0.000319% chance of mission success.”

Catra accepts this for what it is, knowing that there’s sentiment behind the numbers. “Thanks, Entrapta.”

“I do have a little bit of bad news, though,” Entrapta says. “While we managed to catch you during your ascent from the underworld, Darla’s thrusters and starboard navigation coil were moderately damaged. We will have to stay here in the Scorpion Kingdom for a couple days while I take care of repairs.”

“That’s more than fine,” Scorpia says cheerfully. “I’d love to have you all. We’ve got plenty of room.”

The Scorpion Kingdom. Catra rolls the name around, testing it out. It’s truly not the Fright Zone anymore: not by name, not by nature.

“Catra,” Micah says, sitting forward in his seat at the head of the table. “You’re safe, and so is Adora. I know we haven’t known each other long, but having you back is one of the best things that’s ever happened to me.”

Catra swallows hard, a lump of emotion suddenly rising in her throat. Micah is smiling at her gently, and the kindness is almost unbearable. She doesn’t know how to accept it.

She tries anyway. She’s tired of living within the lines of cruelty.

“Thank you,” she says.

Micah nods. Catra’s eyes catch on the color of his shirt: a pale lavender, like sunset over the Crystal Falls. She remembers a pit, a pair of wings, a promise.

“Micah,” she says. “Glimmer. Bow. I have to tell you something.”

Micah looks at her expectantly. Bow and Glimmer, hearing the undertone of sadness in Catra’s voice, watch her carefully.

“I met Angella,” Catra says softly. “Down in the underworld. She helped me. And she said - she said to tell you she loves you.”

“Oh,” Micah says, his eyes bright with tears but shining with love.

Glimmer and Bow are both crying: Bow openly, Glimmer trying to hide it. The two of them press closer to Micah, the movement almost unconscious, and Catra feels an ache in her heart as she watches the three of them. They might be missing one person, but they look like a true family.

“Thank you,” Glimmer says to her, the simple phrase carrying the weight of absolution.

Catra nods. Glimmer breaks away from Bow and Micah to hug her again, and it’s rough and awkward, but Catra sinks into it.

--

Adora doesn’t emerge from her room all day, and her absence is a gnawing fear that clings to Catra, sliding between her ribs like a blade. She knows that Adora is still recovering, and she knows that what they’ve been through would cause anyone to oversleep, and she knows that she herself is not quite recovered either - her knees are still weak, and her breaths come in shallow gasps of pain when she stands for too long - but she worries anyway.

She checks on Adora hourly, until Glimmer pulls her away and suggests, in a gentle but uncompromising tone, that Catra should focus on regaining her own strength instead of working herself up over nothing. Her logic is infuriatingly rational, and Catra wants to argue, but she doesn’t; instead, she goes outside to help Entrapta with ship repairs.

When Catra arrives, Entrapta has Darla’s gangplank down, and there’s an open panel on the hull that’s sparking uncontrollably. Catra assumes by the sound of mumbled calculations coming from the center of the smoke that Entrapta has everything under control, so she sits down on a box to wait.

She looks around, cataloguing the new appearance of the buildings she’s known for so long. Instead of their former sickly grey-green, the roofs and walls are now a warm shade of seafoam. Plants grow along the paths, trees spreading their branches out past the rooftops. The fog that used to hang low over the Fright Zone has vanished, replaced by clear air and a sky full of light. It’s all bright and welcoming, so far from the cold and punishing military compound that it used to be.

Catra should feel relieved about this. Victorious, even. The place that tormented her for years has become something else entirely, burying layers of terror beneath new growth. And she is relieved - she *is* - but there's an edge to it; an unexpected sting, a sense of loss that tastes like metal in her mouth.

I can never return home, she thinks, and then: *It doesn't matter. This was never my home anyway.*

The smoke stops billowing from the hull, and Catra jumps as a shower of sparks fly out.

"Hi there," Entrapta says, catching sight of her. "What are you here for?"

Catra shrugs. "I thought maybe I could help, or something."

Entrapta tips her head to one side, considering. "I wouldn't recommend it. I'm attempting a few experimental additions along with repairs, and the combustions that might occur as a result would probably be dangerous to inflict upon someone of your current health status."

"That's fine," Catra says. "I'll just sit and watch, if that's okay."

"Oh. Sure." Entrapta reaches for a wrench.

Catra inspects the hull damage. There's panels missing, as well as a deep gouge in the metal, and a jumbled mess of colored wires is spilling out.

"What happened?" she asks. "To the ship, I mean."

"Well," Entrapta says, muffled by the spandriver now held between her teeth, "while you were in the underworld, we flew around Etheria waiting for you to surface. I knew that the egress point could be anywhere, so I set up a tracking program on Darla that would allow her to hone in on your signatures as soon as they reappeared and fly to that location within seconds."

She takes the spandriver out, turns a few bolts. “You were falling out of the sky just beyond the Fright Zone, and we managed to catch you, but there was a...kind of disturbance that came along with you, like a rift between dimensions. Similar to the portal, but black instead of white. It closed up after you fell out, but not before carving out part of Darla’s hull. Poor girl.” She pats said hull affectionately.

There’s something welling up in Catra’s chest as she listens to Entrapta speak: it’s a sick, painful kind of gratitude. She’s never been in the habit of repaying debts, and she doesn’t know how she’ll ever manage to settle this one.

“Thanks,” she says. “And Entrapta - I’m sorry. About Beast Island. About the portal.”

This is an apology she has to verbalize, and she knows it, but the words fall out heavily, awkwardly. They’ll never be enough. Catra braces herself for Entrapta’s anger, for the rejection of her insufficient apologies.

Entrapta sets down her tools, facing Catra with an uncharacteristic seriousness in her eyes. “I’ve never been great at making friends,” she says, quiet. “I don’t understand relationships very well. I’m more at home with machines than people. But I’m learning, I think. I’m learning that if you meet the right people, if you really care about them, then they’ll forgive you even when you make mistakes.” She pauses, her expression gentle. “I forgive you, Catra. I won’t forget it, but I will forgive you.”

“Okay,” Catra says, shifting around awkwardly, once again trying to hold the unwieldy shape of unexpected forgiveness.

“Now,” Entrapta says, reverting back to her normal enthusiastic self like the conversation never happened, “I need to run some more tests.” She lets out an ear-splitting whistle. “Darla! Fire up the hyperdrive thrusters at seventy percent capacity!”

Catra smiles slightly, watching as Entrapta loses herself in her work. She thinks about going back inside, but decides against it. Even despite the hum of machinery and the clatter of metal, there's something calming about watching Entrapta fiddle with the ship's engines.

It's not a complete distraction from thinking about Adora, but it's closer than anything else she's likely to get around here.

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The day wears on, and Catra's eyes begin to close; she leans back against the wall, drifting into sleep. Hours slip away as she drowses, warm in the patch of light that falls over her like a veil. It's only when Glimmer comes outside, banging the door closed behind her, that Catra wakes up again.

"Hey," Glimmer says, and Catra realizes that it's nighttime now; the last of the light is fading, yielding to the indigo spill of night. "It's time for dinner."

"Okay," Catra says, still half asleep. There's a pinched expression on Glimmer's face; in her languid state, Catra can't parse it right away. "Is there something wrong?"

"Don't freak out."

Catra surges to her feet, all traces of sleep banished immediately. "You realize that saying *don't freak out* is the best way to make someone freak out, right? What's wrong? Is it Adora?"

"There's nothing *wrong* with her," Glimmer says. "It's just that when I went to tell her about dinner, she wasn't in her room. And now I can't find her anywhere." She frowns in agitation. "I checked like, every room in the building."

"Oh," Catra says, allowing herself to breathe again. "That's all?"

Glimmer glares at her. "That's *all* ? She could have been kidnapped! She could have gone missing!"

“Overdramatics as usual, Sparkles,” Catra says. She pushes past Glimmer, into the hallway. “I know exactly where she is.”

Glimmer follows her down the hall, looking irate. “What do you mean? How do you know where she is?”

“Because,” Catra says. She thinks of her days in the Horde, thinks of the one place they’d always go to find sanctuary. In her mind, it’s still the same as it ever was: unstable railings, corroded metal, a fix that had only ever been temporary. “We’re in the Fright Zone. There’s only one place she’d be.”

--

The rooftop, like everything else in the Fright Zone, has changed. The once unsteady platform now looks sturdy and inviting; the railings shine of copper and silver instead of the rusted iron they used to be. Light green vines of ivy weave around the tower, their small white blossoms a burst of brightness in the falling dusk.

There’s one thing that hasn’t changed, though. As Catra reaches the roof, she sees a silhouette against the sky: a person seated by the edge of the rooftop, hands braced against the railing, golden hair tied back neatly.

Nostalgia sweeps through Catra, an almost pleasant pang of regret. For one fleeting second, it’s as if the war never happened. This could be any one of a million nights on the roof; before the war, before the separation, before the underworld.

Adora turns, and the illusion is blown away. This isn’t the beginning; it’s the aftermath, and all they can do now is live with it.

“Hey,” Catra says, because she doesn’t know what else to say. She doesn’t know what to do. She doesn’t know where to put her hands. She settles for sitting next to Adora, leaving six inches between them.

Adora slides away subtly. The movement tears through Catra's heart like a lightning bolt.

"You found me," Adora says at last, stating the obvious.

Catra scoffs. "You weren't hiding very well."

"I wasn't hiding," Adora says. "I was just - " She plucks a flower from one of the ivy vines, her sentence lingering unfinished in the air between them.

Catra studies her carefully, drinking her in like water. Adora is wearing her old red jacket, now torn and tattered from their battle; her face is scraped, with a bruise smearing purple along the curve of her cheekbone, and her left hand bears a blue medpatch identical to the one on Catra's right hand. Her hair is tied up like it always is, although messier than usual, and there's something glinting in it, platinum in the moonlight. Catra looks more closely, her stomach twisting as she realizes that it's a streak of grey.

"Adora," she says. "What happened to your hair?"

Adora frowns, pulls the strand free, looks at it. "It turned grey," she says. "From the underworld, I guess." Her gaze flickers over Catra, catching on the left side of her head. "You've got one, too."

"Oh," Catra mumbles. Something inside her revolts at this, dismayed at the idea of a permanent reminder of her journey. Something else rises against this, strangely pleased at the thought of sharing this with Adora.

They sit together, the night spread out before them like the sea. There are stars now, stars where there never were before; the sky is lit with thousands of tiny sparks, an endless spill of white light across the infinite expanse of darkness. The moon hangs above them, haloed in a soft pearlescent glow that shines pink in the night, a quarter-waning blush of rose.

Catra stretches. Adora shifts. They're still not talking, and Catra doesn't understand how they can't find a word to say to each other even after all of this.

Finally, she can't take it anymore.

"Why are you avoiding me?"

Adora winces as if Catra has hit her, and she might as well have; she lets the question fall like a knife, cutting through the heart of the silence.

"I'm not," Adora says, more a question than a statement.

Catra bites her lip hard enough that the split starts bleeding again. "Tell me the truth, Adora." Then, quieter: "Please."

Adora sighs shakily, pressing her hands against the tops of her thighs. Catra watches as the color slowly bleeds from her fingertips.

"I remember," Adora says at last. "I don't know if it's because we're not in the underworld or what, but...I remember. Everything."

It falls between them like a sword, that murmured exhalation of *everything* splitting them apart like a canyon. Catra feels it in her chest, a slow and steady pulse of heartache, and beneath that -

Beneath that, a simmering burn of anger that smolders like a fire stifled in earth.

"Are you serious?" Catra asks, every word a sharp and jagged edge in her mouth. "You're seriously saying this*,* Adora?" She laughs bitterly, no humor in it at all. "You don't like what you saw, fine. Pretend it never happened, if you want. But *avoiding* me after I literally dragged your soul back from the underworld? That's low."

“Catra - ”

“Don’t, Adora,” Catra says, shaking her head. She’s exhausted suddenly, weary down to her bones. “Just don’t. I’m not trying to guilt you over this. I still would have saved you if I’d known that you’d end up hating me for it. If I’m being honest, I would have saved you even if it cost my own life to do it. I don’t expect anything from you, okay? None of those other realities were true, even if I wish they had been. You’re never going to want me the way I want you, and I’ll tell myself I’m fine with that every day until it becomes true. But if you’re so disgusted by the idea of being with me that you can’t even stand to be around me, the *real* me, just because the underworld decided to fuck with our heads and make us dream that we were together like that - ”

“What are you talking about?” Adora asks, her eyes wide. “That’s not why I’m avoiding you!”

“Don’t lie to me!” Catra spits out. “What else could it possibly be?”

“Catra, I *killed* you!”

Catra is stunned into silence. Adora pushes her hands through her hair, fingers knotted in golden waves. There’s a desperate kind of anguish written across her face, and Catra suddenly longs to take it from her, to wrap her arms around Adora and hold her until the pain disappears.

“I killed you,” Adora repeats, staring at her own hands as if imagining them covered in blood. “In that clearing. I took your sword and stabbed you through the heart.”

“No,” Catra says. “No, Adora, that wasn’t you. You were possessed or something, I saw your eyes - ”

“But I knew I was doing it!” Adora bursts out. “I could see myself lifting the sword, and I wanted to stop, but it was like I wasn’t in control of my own body. There was someone else making me

move, making me think, and all I did was let it happen. How can I trust myself to be around you after that?”

Catra reaches over and takes Adora’s hand. Adora flinches, but doesn’t pull away.

“I trust you,” Catra says. “I trust you, okay? You won’t hurt me again.”

“You don’t know that,” Adora says.

“Yes,” Catra says, quiet. "I do."

Something haunted flickers across Adora’s face, dark and pained. “I killed her, too.”

She doesn’t have to explain. They both know who she’s talking about.

“She was already dead,” Catra says. “And even if she wasn’t, she deserved it, okay? Fuck. She *deserved* it.”

“I know,” Adora mumbles. “I get that now. But I still feel - ”

“I do too,” Catra says. “But we’ll get past it. We’re finally free of her, and it’s about time.”

“Yeah,” Adora says. The set of her shoulders relaxes. “We are, aren’t we? We’re free.” She swallows hard. "Catra, I'm so sorry for not doing more to protect you from her back then. I should've saved you."

The apology rushes over Catra like spring, the last of the winter fading away. She's been waiting so long for this apology, but now that she's got it, there's none of the self righteous satisfaction that she thought it would have; only a sense of peace.

"You and your damn hero complex," is all she says. "I forgive you. We both had to save ourselves, anyway. She was the villain, not either of us."

Adora sighs, and then she slowly leans towards Catra until their shoulders brush. Catra softens beneath her touch, the two of them collapsing into each other until they're as close as they used to be every time they sat on this rooftop.

"Do you remember the time we sat up here and I told you about the stars?" Adora asks.

"And I said you sounded like an idiot? Yeah, I remember." Catra rests her head on Adora's shoulder. "I thought you sounded like an idiot, but I guess you were right."

Adora smiles; it's a small crease at the corner of her mouth, nothing like the full brightness of her usual crooked grin, but it's a smile nonetheless. "Want to repeat that?"

"Fuck off," Catra says. "You were right. Happy now?"

"Honestly?" Adora says softly. "I think I am." She taps Catra's thigh gently. "You know what you said earlier? About pretending that those other realities didn't happen?"

Catra's heart sinks like a stone, free-falling to the bottom of the ocean. "Yeah. I get it, okay? It was all a trick of the underworld anyway." She forces a laugh that slips out awkwardly, flat and discordant. "It's fine."

"No," Adora says. "That's not what I want." She takes a deep breath, catches Catra's eye. "Catra, I - I love you."

Catra stares at her, disbelieving. Her heart is beating wildly, threatening to climb out of her chest and sew itself to her sleeve; her blood feels like electricity, fire flowing through her veins and burning beneath her skin. There are stars exploding in her throat and comets colliding between her ribs, an entire world bursting into creation in her mouth, timelines and tidelines bending to the rhythm of her heart - surely she's misheard, surely she's dreaming -

“What?” she manages to say, a lifetime of hope hanging on the edge of the word.

“I love you,” Adora says again, and the reaffirmation rushes through Catra all over again; she breathes it in like oxygen, lightheaded and euphoric. “Unless you weren’t saying that you want me and I was reading this entire thing wrong, which would change things. I mean, it wouldn’t change how I feel about you, because I love you either way, but it would be embarrassing if it wasn’t - ”

Catra presses her hands to Adora’s jawline, cradling her face. Adora promptly stops talking.

“You’re such an idiot,” Catra says, the sentence colored bright with happiness. She feels like she’s falling, like she’s flying. She feels like she’s exploding out of her body, becoming a star, becoming heat and light, the whole of her being a chorus of elation.

She leans in and kisses Adora, and it feels like an eclipse.

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“So,” Catra says at the breakfast table the next morning, looking around accusingly at her friends, “was anyone going to tell me that my hair is literally going grey, or did I just have to figure that out myself?”

--

They return to Bright Moon a day later, leaving Perfuma and Scorpia back in what is now the Scorpion Kingdom. The trip takes longer than it should, and they’re still tired and wounded, but all of Catra’s exhaustion falls away when Bright Moon comes into view.

She stands on the bridge of the ship with Adora and Bow and Glimmer and Micah, and the five of them watch as the palace comes into view in the distance, all shining stone and gleaming towers. Catra looks at the castle and thinks of the future, and for

the first time since she can remember, it looks like something bright and infinite.

Adora, standing next to her, finds Catra's hand and laces their fingers together. "It's beautiful, isn't it?"

"Yeah," Catra says, looking directly at her. "It is."

--

Later that night, after a meal shared with Micah and Glimmer and Bow, after a midnight kitchen raid spent sitting on the floor and eating cake straight from the pan, Catra and Adora find their way to Adora's room. There's a proper bed there now, courtesy of Bow: it's big enough for the two of them, with an unyielding mattress to compensate for Adora's dislike of the typical Bright Moon featherbeds.

In the corner of the room, the quiet rush of the waterfall echoes like the waves of the ocean. Moonlight spills through the window, bathing them in silver luminescence. Their bed is a river that no one has ever drowned in, and their ceiling is the late night sky.

Catra takes Adora's left hand, turning it over to reveal the scar on her palm: a round patch of scar tissue that forms a perfect circle. Its silvery white shine is the exact match of the crescent-shaped scar on Catra's right hand.

"Entrapta said she could probably fix them, if we wanted," Adora says, tracing a finger over Catra's scar. "What do you think?"

Catra shrugs. "I don't know. I think they're kind of cool."

"Like a reminder," Adora murmurs, and Catra knows what she's thinking. In the Horde, scars had been a certain kind of reminder: a record of mistakes. A permanent mark to show where you went wrong, a warning not to do it again.

"Not that kind of reminder," Catra says. "It's a reminder of *us* ." She kisses Adora's palm, quick and gentle. "A reminder of what

we went through, and how we survived."

"Okay," Adora murmurs. "Yeah. That sounds good." She looks relaxed, settled, and Catra finally gives voice to the fear that's been lingering in the back of her throat.

"Do you think she was right?" she asks. "When she said that we'd lose three years?"

Adora shakes her head slowly. "I don't know, but I don't care even if she was. I'd rather have a limited amount of time with you than eternity without you."

"Oh," Catra says, lightheaded with relief. "Good. Me too." Three years, six months, forty days, a lifetime; it's all the same, in the end. It's time with Adora, and that's all Catra's ever wanted.

Adora smiles now, and Catra can barely breathe past the happiness rising in her chest. They've made it through the war and the underworld; they've made it through the dark and the cold. Now they're in a bedroom full of peace, and they're alive, and they're together.

"I love you," Adora says softly, pressing a kiss to Catra's forehead.

Catra smiles. "I love you too," she says, and they're the truest words she's ever spoken.

Adora leans back against the headboard, pulling Catra closer; Catra presses her head to Adora's chest and listens to the steady beat of her heart, thinking of waltzes, thinking of springtime, thinking of unbroken promises. She tilts her head to look at Adora, reaches up to kiss the smile at the corner of her mouth, and lets herself become tender.

They've died for this love, but now they'll get to live for it, and Catra can't think of anything better.

Chapter End Notes

and that's a wrap on my fic for the 2021 she ra big bang! please leave a comment or kudo...i will not beg i will ask 100 times and that's it. as always, you can find me on twitter

for anyone who'd like it, a list of Notable Things included in this fic (as featured in my notes app outline):

- sun/moon metaphors
- red string of fate
- a blink and you'll miss it tribute to mitski
- an element co opted from homestu- [gunshot]
- richard siken allusions
- the inherent homoeroticism of stabbing someone at a pivotal narrative point
- persephone/hades reference
- horse girl adora
- the grey streaks in the hair thing from pjo the titan's curse
- "to arrive where we started"
- sasunaru smack cam re: hand scars
- "in our bedroom after the war"

and yes the sixth gate is botw inspired. I'm Sorry BOTW Enjoyers.

End Notes

comments and kudos and bookmarks are extremely appreciated and you can find me on twitter and tumblr

and technically speaking yes this is an orpheus/eurydice au but it's gone so far from Just an orpheus/eurydice au that i simply can't tag it as such anymore without being a little dishonest

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!